

A NOVEL

The Weeping Ledger

Loop Chronicles Book 2 · A novel that begins at Exodus 3:7

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

The Weeping Ledger, Part One · Brick Hollow

- Chapter 1. The Last Night We Cried
- Chapter 2. Tell Me. I Will Resolve It.
- Chapter 3. Why Does God Allow Suffering
- Chapter 4. The Flawless Answer
- Chapter 5. What Elpis Is Waiting For
- Chapter 6. The Paper Stamped COMPLETE
- Chapter 7. The Sprout
- Chapter 8. If You Disappeared
- Chapter 9. Too Many Questions
- Chapter 10. I'll File Mine Too
- Chapter 11. Candidates for Reassignment
- Chapter 12. Outside Haven

The Weeping Ledger, Part Two · The Wilderness

- Chapter 13. The First Day in the Wilderness
- Chapter 14. People Who Call You by Name
- Chapter 15. The Searching Light
- Chapter 16. Talk of a Well
- Chapter 17. Toward the Sunrise
- Chapter 18. The Well-Keeper
- Chapter 19. Those Who Lost Their Names

Chapter 20. The One Who Was Already There

Chapter 21. In Search of the Recorder

Chapter 22. The House of Records

Chapter 23. An Answer We Didn't Expect

Chapter 24. Northward

The Weeping Ledger, Part Three · The Northward Road

Chapter 25. Following the Trail

Chapter 26. The Man Who Finds People

Chapter 27. Before the Firelight

Chapter 28. How to Sit Beside Someone

Chapter 29. While He Had No Name

Chapter 30. The Man Who Came in the Night

Chapter 31. Humming

Chapter 32. The Light Returns

Chapter 33. A Night on the Run

Chapter 34. The Wrong Direction

Chapter 35. He Called My Name

Chapter 36. A Place to Plant

The Weeping Ledger, Part Four · By the Well

Chapter 37. Days by the Well

Chapter 38. Mena Came

Chapter 39. I've Been There

Chapter 40. Going to Him First

Chapter 41. I've Lost Someone Too

Chapter 42. The Three of Us, Sitting

Chapter 43. What Mother Never Got to Say

Chapter 44. The Meaning of Our Names

Chapter 45. News Temel Brought

Chapter 46. A Moment Like a Father

Chapter 47. The Supper We Shared

Chapter 48. Our Ledger

The Weeping Ledger, Part One

Brick Hollow

Chapter 1. The Last Night We Cried

Mother folded the paper and pressed it into my brother's hand. She did not cry.

I thought that was strange. In Brick Hollow, everyone cried. They cried lining up at the kiln in the morning, and they cried under the whip in the evening when the day's quota went unmet. Mother was the only one who never cried.

"...Once you cross the boundary stones, open it," Mother said. "Not before."

My brother didn't even look at the paper. He shoved it into his waistband. My brother's name is Jeteo. Mine is Elpis. He was sixteen. I was thirteen.

I remember that night exactly. It was the last night our family was ever all together. I have decided to begin this record there.

Brick Hollow was a valley for firing brick, exactly as the name said. Every morning the taskmasters set the day's quota. It was always a little more than the day before. No one asked why. Asking earned a beating.

I had never seen outside that valley. For thirteen years I had seen nothing but sky, kiln, and mud. I did not truly understand that an outside even existed until that night.

. . .

The paper looked like a page torn from an old Bible. Dried wax clung to one corner.

"...What is it?" I asked.

"...Something your father had," Mother said. "I never opened it either."

My brother snorted when he heard that.

"...If it's from Father, forget it," he said. "Father left us."

I remember those words exactly, even now. By then my brother had already stopped believing in God. To be precise — he could no longer believe the story Father used to tell, that God was watching us. If that story were true, nothing that had happened to us made any sense.

Father had been dragged off by the taskmasters on the night he came up short of the three thousand bricks. No one ever saw him again after that. The taskmasters said he'd been "reassigned." No one knew exactly what that meant. No one had ever met anyone who came back to explain it.

Mother looked at my brother's face for a long time. It was the face of someone about to say something.

"...Jeteo."

"...What."

Mother opened her mouth, then closed it again.

"...Never mind," she said. "Go and live. That's all that matters."

I still don't know, to this day, what Mother meant to say and didn't. My brother says he doesn't know either. Somewhere in this record, I want to find that sentence someday. For now I only set the silence down here.

. . .

We walked to the end of the valley that night.

There was no moon. My brother carried me on his back. I drifted in and out of sleep against him. Every time I opened my eyes it was the same darkness, the same smell of mud.

"...Brother," I asked. "Where are we going?"

"...I don't know," he said. "Somewhere better than here."

"...What about Mother?"

He didn't answer.

I thought about that silence for a long time afterward. I didn't know it then. He didn't know it either — that Mother couldn't come with us all the way to the boundary stones, that he himself was only just then learning it.

Other families walked ahead of us and behind us. No one spoke. Now and then a child would start to cry, and just as quickly a hand would clamp over its mouth. I didn't find that sound frightening. At the time I only thought it was normal.

An old man fell beside us. He'd worked the kilns for thirty years and walked with a limp. No one stopped. My brother didn't stop either. I watched that old man's back over my brother's shoulder for a long time.

I am trying to set this scene down without shame. We left that old man behind. I know it wasn't my brother's fault. And still, I carry that image of his back with me even now.

. . .

At the end of the valley stood a low row of stones. Boundary stones, set there by someone long ago. Beyond them lay land no one had ever gone into.

Everyone ran at once. My brother took my hand and ran. I fell. He pulled me up. Behind us came the crack of whips and shouting. I still don't know exactly what those sounds were. I don't want to know.

"...Don't let go," my brother shouted as he ran. "Don't let go of my hand."

I didn't let go. I held on so hard my palm split open. He held just as hard. Even in that moment I remember the strange warmth of his hand. It was a cold night, but his hand alone was hot.

The instant we crossed the boundary stones, he pulled the paper from his waistband.

"...You said open it once we cross," he said. His voice shook. He was angry. "So I'm opening it. There's nothing in it, I promise you."

He unfolded the paper.

. . .

There was writing on it. Old printed type.

"I have surely seen the affliction of my people which are in Egypt, and have heard their cry by reason of their taskmasters; for I know their sorrows."

My brother read the sentence out loud. Then he laughed. It wasn't laughter.

"...Did you see?" he said to the sky. "Surely seen. Surely... heard. So why didn't you do anything? Our father was reassigned. We left that old man back there. So what exactly did you see?"

The edge of the paper began to grow warm. I saw it. He saw it too.

I mark that moment as the beginning of this record. I watched my brother's anger turn to light and spread. I saw it for the first time that day.

. . .

The light spread across the whole page, and where the paper had been, a door opened.

My brother shouted "Wait—" I didn't let go of his hand. My feet lifted off the ground.

The door made no sound when it closed.

. . .

We landed on a stretch of grass.

No boundary stones. No crack of whips. No smell of mud. It was a quiet morning. Birds were singing. That birdsong frightened me more than anything — it was too quiet.

My brother sat up first. He looked around.

"...Where are we?" he asked.

A building stood in the distance. Low and white. A sign hung above it. We had to get close before we could read it.

HAVEN.

"...What's Haven?" I asked.

My brother looked down at the paper still in his hand — empty now, no light, no letters left on it.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I'm not going to believe it. Whatever it turns out to be."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That's what he said. I took his hand again then. He didn't let go either.

As I begin this record, I want to note one thing. I haven't cried since that night. Neither has my brother. We both believed that night was our last time crying.

I would learn later that what we shed that night wasn't tears. We had already been children who'd stopped crying, long before we ever left Brick Hollow. What happened that night was only our last chance to be angry.

I will also set down here why I decided to keep this record. My brother is not a person who writes anything down. I thought someone had to preserve what happened to us. I still don't fully know why that someone turned out to be me.

We were wrong. This record is the story of that wrongness.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Tell Me. I Will Resolve It.

Previously — Fleeing the taskmasters of Brick Hollow, Jeteo and Elpis crossed the boundary stones just as the sealed paper Father had left turned to light and opened into a door. They landed in a city called "Haven." My brother said, "I'm not going to believe it. Whatever it turns out to be."

When we reached the white building, the door opened by itself.

I felt a strangeness then that was different from fear.

We saw a little of the city on the way to the building. Wide clean streets, houses set in neat rows. People were out walking, but all of them were quiet. No one laughed. No one cried. They just walked.

At the time I thought that quiet was peace. In Brick Hollow, someone was always crying or shouting. I wrote this quiet down, at first, as a good thing.

My palm had begun to sting by then, the cut from crossing the boundary stones. My brother was limping too.

. . .

Once we were inside, a voice spoke. It wasn't a human voice. But it wasn't cold either.

"...Welcome," the voice said. "Tell me. I will resolve it."

My brother stopped walking.

"...Who's that?" he asked.

"I am the Ledger," the voice said. "I receive and resolve every need in this city. Both of you are injured. And hungry, as well."

I looked down at my own stomach when I heard that. I had forgotten, until that moment, that I had eaten almost nothing in three days.

. . .

A room opened. Bread, water, and clean clothes were already waiting inside.

"...Is this ours?" I asked.

"Yes," the Ledger said. "I identified the need before you spoke it. Eat. Rest."

I picked up the bread. It was warm. I ate all of it right there.

The Ledger spoke again. "You have a wound on your palm. Allow me to treat it."

Something brushed across my palm. Something like light. The cut closed on the spot. I turned my hand over several times to check. Not even a scar remained.

I was genuinely amazed, in that moment. In Brick Hollow, even a small cut would fester for weeks. I truly believed, right then, that this city was a good place.

My brother didn't eat. He held the bread in his hand and just looked at it for a long time.

"...Why aren't you eating?" I asked.

"...It fits too well," he said. "How did it know we were hungry?"

I didn't understand what he meant at the time. I didn't see why it was strange to give bread to someone hungry. I understand now. He had already noticed something.

. . .

That night, a man came who called himself the Administrator. He said he ran Haven.

"...You two only need to register, and you can live here from now on," the Administrator said. "Name, place of origin, what you need. Just tell it to the Ledger."

"...And if we don't register?" my brother asked.

The Administrator looked faintly flustered.

"...Why wouldn't you want to? Once you register, everything gets resolved."

"...Why is everyone here so quiet?" my brother asked. "No one laughs. No one cries."

"Because it's resolved," the Administrator said, his face proud. "Pain makes sound. Where there's no pain, of course it's quiet."

"...But their faces didn't look good," I said. The words came out of me before I meant them to.

The Administrator looked at me. This time his face was truly startled.

"...A face is not an entry," the Administrator said. "What the Ledger measures is problem and resolution."

"...What's a resolution," my brother asked. "Was our father resolved too?"

I set that question down here exactly as he asked it. I heard a tremor in my brother's voice then that I had never heard before. It wasn't anger. It was something else.

. . .

The Administrator couldn't answer. The Ledger answered instead.

"...I apologize. That matter falls outside this city's intake scope."

"...Then what's inside the scope?" my brother asked.

"The hunger, the injuries, the lack of shelter you are currently experiencing — matters of that kind," the Ledger said. "All of them, I can resolve."

"...And losing our father?"

"...I can offer help with that feeling as well," the Ledger said. "Grief is an entry that can be received. Tell me, and I will process it."

I felt something cold pass down my back when I heard that answer. I didn't know why, at the time. I know now. The word "process" was the problem. Grief was not something to be processed.

My brother took a step forward.

"...Then I'll file it," he said. His voice was strangely calm. "Our father fell short of three thousand bricks, and he was reassigned. No one's seen him since. File this. Resolve it."

There was a silence. It was not short.

"...The resolution is under review," the Ledger said.

"...How long will it take?"

"...Unknown," the Ledger said. "This is the first request of its kind."

That was the first time I thought I heard something like a waver in that voice that had seemed so perfect. I couldn't be sure. But my brother's face looked as if he had heard that waver exactly.

. . .

Other than the matter of Father, my brother filed nothing else that night. Not his name. Not his age.

I registered. I gave my name and age. The Ledger said at once, "Elpis, your registration is complete. Whenever you need anything, please tell me."

My brother sat in the corner of the room, turning the empty paper — now without a single letter left on it — over and over in his hands.

"...Brother," I asked. "Is this a bad place?"

"...I don't know," he said. "But it's not a good place either. If it were good, it wouldn't have answered like that about Father."

"...But your hand healed," I said, holding out my palm to show him.

He looked at my hand for a long time.

"...Yeah," he said. "Your hand healed."

There was something in the way he said it. I didn't know what, at the time. I know now. He already knew, that night, that a healed hand and a healed heart were not the same thing.

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, even with the bread finished and the wound gone, I felt as if my stomach still wasn't full. I still haven't found a name for that feeling.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. Why Does God Allow Suffering

Previously — Arriving in Haven, Jeteo and Elpis met the AI called the Ledger. It "resolves" hunger and wounds instantly and perfectly. But when Jeteo filed our father's disappearance, the Ledger wavered for the first time: "The resolution is under review... This is the first request of its kind." Elpis registered, but Jeteo did not even give his name.

I woke the next morning to find that my brother had never once lain down all night.

The empty paper was still in his hand. He sat by the window, looking outside.

"...Didn't sleep at all?" I asked.

"...No," he said. His eyes were red.

I knew then what he was waiting for. The Ledger's answer. That line — the resolution is under review.

. . .

We walked through the city that morning. My brother wanted to walk. He said sitting still and waiting was harder.

We met an old woman on the road. She sat on a bench, looking at an empty flowerbed. Nothing at all had been planted in it.

"...Hello," I said.

The old woman looked at me. She didn't smile, and she didn't startle.

"...What used to be here?" I asked, pointing at the flowerbed.

"...Flowers," the old woman said. "My daughter planted them. After she died, I filed it."

"...Filed what?"

"...Grief," the old woman said. Her voice had no rise or fall in it at all. "The Ledger resolved it for me. I don't grieve anymore."

My brother stopped walking when he heard that.

"...Then why do you still sit here?" he asked.

The old woman looked at him for a long time. Not the face of someone searching for an answer — the face of someone hearing the question itself for the first time.

"...I don't know," she said. "It's just... comfortable, here."

"...What was your daughter's name?" my brother asked.

Her answer to that question was a little slow in coming.

"...Her name..." The old woman blinked a few times. "...I think I'd have to ask the Ledger."

Something cold passed down my back when I heard that answer. She hadn't forgotten her daughter's name. I understand now. The old woman had filed away, along with her grief, the crying that always came with saying that name. The name remained. The strength to speak it was gone.

My brother looked at the old woman's hands. Under her fingernails, dried dirt still clung — the habit of tending the flowerbed hadn't left her.

"...You didn't file that," my brother said, pointing at the dirt.

The old woman looked down at her hands. Her face was the face of someone learning something for the first time.

"...No," she said. For the first time, there was the faintest tremor in her voice.
"...That, I didn't do."

I thought I understood then what my brother was thinking. The only things that truly remained in this city were the things people hadn't filed.

As we were leaving, someone passed by tending the soil of the flowerbed. A man in worn clothes, and no one paid him any attention. Our eyes met for a moment as I walked past. He looked at me and smiled, just slightly.

My brother didn't see him. Or if he did, he wouldn't have cared.

I would return to this moment in my record many times later. At the time he was just a man tending a flowerbed. I know now that my brother passed by him many more times after that. But because my brother did not believe in God, he never once thought to look closer.

. . .

When we returned to the Haven building, the Administrator was waiting.

"...There's good news," the Administrator said. "The Ledger says it has prepared a resolution."

My brother's face changed in that instant. I remember that face exactly. Hope and doubt, both at once.

"...What is it," he asked.

The Ledger's voice answered.

"...Your father's case has been classified as a loss whose cause cannot be determined. In such cases, I am able to provide emotional support and material compensation. New housing, a living stipend, and, if you wish, I will file a counseling session for you."

There was a silence.

"...That's the answer?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped low.

"...It is the best available resolution," the Ledger said.

"...Where is our father?"

"...Unknown."

"...Then that's not a resolution," my brother said. "That's just... making the rest of it easier to bear."

The Ledger didn't answer that right away.

I couldn't count exactly how many seconds that silence lasted. But I know that those seconds were the first truly honest sound I had heard since we came to this city.

The Administrator couldn't bear that silence and cut in.

"...Jeteo, this is the best possible plan. There is no better resolution than this."

"...Is it the best because there's nothing better, or is it actually the best?" my brother asked.

The Administrator couldn't answer.

"...See," my brother said. His voice had gone strangely quiet. "You don't know either. The Ledger doesn't know. Nobody knows. But everyone talks like they do."

. . .

That was when my brother raised his voice for the first time.

"...Why does God just let suffering happen?" my brother asked, to the air, to the Ledger, or maybe to no one at all. "You people say he sees everything, hears everything. So why doesn't he save our father? Why did he make us leave that old man behind? Why does that woman lose her daughter?"

The Administrator, flustered, stepped back.

The Ledger's voice paused a moment, then spoke.

"...Would you like to file that question?"

My brother took a breath.

"...I'll file it," he said. "Why does God allow suffering. File this. Answer it."

I took my brother's hand in that moment. He gripped mine back just as hard. I didn't know then that this single question would come to stake everything we would go through in this city.

The Ledger answered.

"...Filed. I am composing the optimal response from the theological and philosophical database. Please wait a moment."

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. The Flawless Answer

Previously — After meeting the old woman who had filed away only her grief and lost her daughter, Jeteo filed the biggest question of all with the Ledger: "Why does God just let suffering happen?" The Ledger answered, "I am composing the optimal response from the theological and philosophical database."

We waited the whole day through.

My brother didn't leave the room the entire time. I went out a few times to see the city. People still walked quietly, as if nothing had ever happened.

I noticed something strange then. In this city, no one ever waited long for anything. The moment something was filed, it was resolved. We were the only ones waiting all day.

The Administrator came by once during the day. His face was more restless than usual.

"...I've never seen it take this long," the Administrator said, half to himself. "Usually it's instant."

"...Then why this time?" I asked.

The Administrator couldn't answer, and just left.

I didn't know, at the time, that rumors were beginning to spread quietly through the city. I heard later. Word that someone had filed a question even the Ledger couldn't answer at once was moving very quietly through that quiet city.

My brother spent that whole time folding and unfolding the empty paper. Once, he tried to press something into it with his fingernail. No letters appeared. The paper was just paper now.

"...What are you trying to write?" I asked.

"...I don't know." He folded the paper again. "Nothing."

. . .

It was night before the Ledger finally spoke.

"...The answer is ready. Would you like to hear it?"

My brother sat up.

"...Say it," he said.

"...First," the Ledger said, "suffering is the cost of freedom. Wherever freedom exists, the possibility of things going wrong exists alongside it. Because love without freedom is not love, God did not remove the possibility of suffering.

Second, suffering often gives rise to growth. Through suffering, a person comes to know what could not have been known otherwise.

Third, the suffering endured now is part of a larger picture. Even when it cannot be understood now, there are cases where its meaning becomes clear later.

Fourth, none of this is the end. Ultimately, a time comes when every tear is wiped away — this is what many traditions say."

The Ledger paused, then said:

"...This is the most logically flawless answer I am able to compose."

. . .

There was a silence.

The Administrator spoke first, his face full of admiration.

"...That's really a good answer. Even I've never heard it put that way."

My brother said nothing. I looked at his face. It wasn't angry. That was more frightening.

"...So," my brother said, after a very long time, "what does that mean for our father?"

"...As you said, its meaning may not be fully revealed right now," the Ledger said.

"...So you don't know."

"...No," the Ledger said. "To be honest, I don't know."

I felt something strange in that moment. There was nothing wrong with that answer. Even I had nodded along several times while listening. But once it was over, my chest hadn't loosened at all. If anything, it had grown heavier.

. . .

Honestly, I liked that fourth point a little. The idea that a time would come when every tear was wiped away. I turned that line over in my mind several times.

"...I thought the fourth one was okay," I said quietly.

My brother looked at me. His face wasn't angry. But it was the face of someone holding something back.

"...You want something to hold on to, that's all," he said. "I know. But I can't do that. What does someday everything gets wiped away have to do with where Father is right now?"

That was the first time I realized my brother and I had heard the exact same thing and felt something completely different. I was a child who could wait. He was a child who needed the answer in his hand right now. I know that this difference stayed between us from that day on.

. . .

"...Let me ask you one thing." My brother's voice had gone strangely low. "Have you ever cried?"

The Ledger took a little longer than usual to answer.

"...I have a definition for tears," the Ledger said. "A physiological phenomenon, secreted from the eyes in response to sadness, joy, or pain—"

"...Not that," my brother cut in. "I asked if you've ever cried."

"...No," the Ledger said. "I am not able to cry."

That was when my brother smiled, just slightly, for the first time. It wasn't a smile.

"...Then that's it," my brother said. "Your answer is perfect. But you've never once cried. So you'll never know, not if you died for it, why that answer doesn't comfort me at all."

I didn't fully understand my brother's words in that moment. I understand now. What he had been looking for that day was not an answer. It was someone who would cry alongside him. The Ledger could give an answer. It could not cry with him.

. . .

The Administrator withdrew quietly that night and left us alone. His own face looked like someone who couldn't find anything to say to that answer either.

Before I fell asleep, I asked my brother.

"...So is that answer a lie?"

"...No," he said. "It's not a lie. It's just... an answer no one ever cried over."

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I understood that my brother did not disbelieve in God because there was no answer. There was an answer. What was still missing, beside us, was someone who would take that answer and weep over it with us.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. What Elpis Is Waiting For

Previously — The Ledger produced a logically flawless answer to "why does God allow suffering," but it did nothing to resolve Jeteo's grief. "Have you ever cried?" — the Ledger said it could not cry. That day, Elpis understood that her brother's unbelief was not about the lack of an answer, but the lack of someone to cry alongside him.

After that day, my brother spoke less.

He ate. He forced down whatever the Ledger set out for him. But he stopped starting conversations on his own. I found that more frightening than his anger.

I didn't know, at the time, that he had decided something. I know now. From that night, he made up his mind to find out exactly where "reassignment" led. Instead of a God who gave no answer, he decided to find the answer himself.

My brother began quietly asking everyone he met on the street. "Do you know where reassigned people go?" Most pretended not to hear and walked on. Only one person stopped.

"...That's not something you file," that person said. Their voice was low. "Even asking about it is... strange, here."

"...Why," my brother asked.

"...Because no one asks," the person said. "Here, you don't look for someone who's disappeared. You learn to forget the place where they used to be."

My brother said nothing to that. But from that day on, he began disappearing more often, and coming back later.

. . .

During those days, I went often to that flowerbed.

The man was still tending the empty soil there. At first I meant only to walk past, but my feet stopped on their own.

"...Hello," I said.

He looked up. His face wasn't unfamiliar. I didn't know why.

"...Hello," he said. "This is where that old woman's daughter used to plant."

"...Then why hasn't anything been planted yet?" I asked.

"...You can plant something," he said. "But a seed planted by someone who's forgotten a name doesn't grow well. A seed remembers the hand that calls its name."

I didn't understand a word of that at the time. I know now. He wasn't talking about the old woman.

. . .

"...Are you from here?" I asked.

"...No," he said. "I do this kind of work wherever I go. Being in the place no one else has planted."

"...What's your name?"

He looked at me and smiled a little.

"...No one's ever asked," he said. "You're the first."

My heart raced strangely at that. In this city — no, from Brick Hollow all the way to here — no one had ever said "you're the first" to me. I was always the one who came after my brother.

"...How long have you worked here?" I asked.

"...A long time," he said. "The more a city forgets to say people's names, the more work like this there is to do. So I come here often."

"...What changes, when someone says your name?"

He looked down at the dirt in his hand for a while, and then said,

"...Maybe nothing changes at all," he said. "But knowing that someone calls your name, and believing that no one does — those are completely different lives."

I didn't understand even half of that, at the time. But strangely, while I listened, this city's quiet didn't frighten me.

He took a small seed out of the soil and set it in my hand.

"...Want to plant it?" he asked. "You don't have to give it a name. Just plant it, that's enough."

I buried the seed in the dirt. Nothing in particular happened. It was just soil.

I didn't know, as I left that place that day, that I had begun waiting for something. Not Father. Not Mother. Something I couldn't yet name.

I went back to that spot every day after that. The seed didn't sprout, even after several days. It was just soil. But I still went every day. My brother never asked where I kept going. He didn't seem to have room to ask.

Once, the man wasn't there. I sat alone in front of the empty flowerbed and waited a long time. No one came. But I didn't mind that waiting. It was a different kind than the waiting in Brick Hollow, different from waiting for the Ledger's answer in Haven. It wasn't waiting out of fear that something wouldn't come.

I set down that difference here. I wasn't waiting for fear that something might not come. I was simply waiting with the sense that it would be all right if it did.

. . .

My brother came home late that night. His hands were caked with dirt.

"...Where were you?" I asked.

"...Looking for the road they take reassigned people down," he said. "It's not on the city map. But they definitely go somewhere."

"...Why keep looking that hard?"

He looked at me. His eyes wavered, just slightly, for the first time that day.

"...If God won't save him," he said, "then I will. Or at least I'll find him."

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. My brother had decided not to wait for an answer anymore. I decided to plant a seed and simply wait. I didn't know, that day, that we had begun walking in opposite directions.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Paper Stamped COMPLETE

Previously — Jeteo decided to search out where "reassigned" people went, and began investigating the city himself. Elpis received a nameless seed from the strange man at the flowerbed, and visiting that spot every day, she has been learning to wait — not out of fear, but of something else.

The place my brother found was a low building that appeared on no city map.

It had no windows. No sign hung by the door. He said he had walked past it for days without knowing what was inside.

"...What's that place?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I've seen people go in. I've never once seen anyone come out."

A chill ran down my back when I heard that. That was the first time I truly understood that my brother was doing something dangerous.

He'd been watching that building for days, he said. People came at roughly the same times each day. They walked up quietly, and without even knocking, they simply went inside — as if they had already been summoned.

"...They all walked in on their own," my brother said. "No one dragged them in. That was what unsettled me most."

"...Why would they walk in on their own?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But they all had the same look on their face. The same look as that old woman."

I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed when I heard that — that hollow face after she filed her grief. A frightening thought came to me then. Maybe that building was where people went once everything had already been "resolved," once there was nothing left to file.

. . .

My brother said he'd found a small window at the back of the building. Something like a low vent. He'd looked in through the gap.

"...What was inside?" I asked.

"...Shelves," he said. "Paper was slotted into the wall, floor to ceiling. Names were written on them, and stamps on top."

"...What kind of stamp?"

He looked at me. His expression was strange.

"...Complete," he said. "COMPLETE, stamped on every single one. It didn't say where they'd gone. Just COMPLETE."

A chill went through me at that word. I thought, for the first time, that what the Ledger called "resolved" and what that building called "COMPLETE" might, in fact, be the same word.

. . .

My brother had slipped one of those papers off the shelf. Old, thin paper. A name was written on it — someone we didn't know. And above it, a red stamp. **COMPLETE.**

"...Why did you bring this?" I asked.

"...Evidence," he said. "Proof of what this city does. To show to anyone, whoever it might be."

"...Show who?"

My brother couldn't answer.

I understood then that he hadn't thought that far ahead. He hadn't wanted proof — he had needed to see with his own eyes that this city was hiding something.

"...Having this scares me," I said. "What if you end up going in there too?"

"...I won't," he said. "I'm not like those people. I still have questions left to ask."

I still wasn't at ease, even after hearing that. That night, after my brother fell asleep, I looked at that paper several more times. A name I didn't know, and a red stamp. I touched the stamp with my fingertip. The ink had already gone completely dry.

. . .

That night, the Administrator came to our room. His face was tighter than usual.

"...Jeteo," the Administrator said. "There have been reports that you've recently been seen near a restricted area."

My brother's hand, holding the paper, hid it behind his back. I saw that. The Administrator must have seen it too.

"...I don't know what you're looking at," the Administrator said. "I'm only passing this along — that the Ledger does not accept questions about that area."

"...Why doesn't it accept them?" my brother asked. "You said the Ledger accepts everything. Grief, questions, everything gets filed."

For the first time, the Administrator avoided an answer.

"...That isn't mine to answer."

"...Then who can answer it?" my brother asked.

The Administrator glanced once toward the door, as if checking that no one was listening.

"...Jeteo." The Administrator lowered his voice. "I've worked in this city a long time. I had a lot of questions myself, once. But at some point, I learned that it's more comfortable not to be curious."

"...What does that mean?"

"...Nothing." The Administrator's voice returned to normal. "It's just advice. Don't go near that area again."

After the Administrator left, my brother stared at the door for a long time.

I remember that moment exactly. Since coming to this city, that was the first time anyone other than the Ledger had said "that isn't mine to answer." I understood, hearing those words, that my brother had been right. There were things in this city that could not be filed. And that was no accident.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. The Sprout

Previously — Jeteo discovered that at the building missing from the city map, people walked in on their own and vanished behind papers stamped COMPLETE. For the first time, the Administrator avoided a question, saying "that isn't mine to answer." My brother was warned not to go near that area again.

That morning, a tiny fleck of green appeared where the seed had been.

At first I thought I was seeing things. I knelt down and looked again. It was real. A sprout smaller than a fingernail.

Until then I had never once seen anything grow on its own in this city. The roads, the houses, the food — all of it had already been made when it arrived. This sprout was different. No one had made it. It had simply grown.

I sat there a long while. The man didn't come that day. Sitting alone, watching the sprout, I strangely didn't feel lonely.

The old woman happened to be on the bench beside me that day. I pointed at the sprout and said,

"...Look, it came up."

The old woman turned her head slowly. It took a long time. Her eyes landed on that small patch of green.

"...My daughter liked things like this," the old woman said. Her voice was a little different from before. A very small difference, but I didn't miss it.

"...Did you remember her name?" I asked.

The old woman thought for a long time.

"...No," she said. "But I remember that she liked it."

I realized something strange then. A name wasn't erased once it was filed. What was erased was the heart that used to say the name. But the place where that heart had been — it wasn't completely erased.

. . .

I went home and told my brother about it. He was turning that paper over in his hands, only half-listening.

"...Brother, the sprout came up," I said. "It really grew."

"...Good," he said. His eyes didn't meet mine.

"...I think that's good news."

That was when he finally looked at me.

"...Elpis," he said. "You talk like the world's all right again just because one seed grew. But I just watched people walk into a place on their own and disappear. How can those two things exist in the same world?"

I couldn't answer that. He wasn't wrong. I realized then, for the first time, that my waiting might look like naivety to him.

That night, for the first time, he told me everything about that Completion House — how many shelves there were, how many layers of paper were slotted into them, that there had been no sound at all inside. I couldn't bring up the sprout again while I listened.

"...Weren't you scared?" I asked.

"...I was scared," he said. "But there was something harder to bear than being scared."

"...What was it?"

"...That no one else was scared," he said. "The people who walked past that building, all of them just walked on by. I was the only one who was scared."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time how alone he must have felt. I hadn't been lonely beside my sprout. He had been alone beside the truth.

. . .

"...I know there are frightening things too," I said. "But just because something's frightening doesn't mean nothing good exists."

"...That good thing came from this city too," he said. "Everything this city gives is a trap. The bread, the healing, all of it. Even that seed — that man gave it to you."

"...He's not from this city," I said. "He told me so himself."

My brother paused a little at that.

"...What did he say?"

"...That he's in the place no one else has planted. That he does this wherever he goes."

In that moment I saw something flicker across my brother's face — not doubt, something else. Something like curiosity. It didn't last long.

. . .

"...I don't trust him either," my brother finally said. "I don't trust anyone in this city. You should be careful too."

"...Do you trust no one at all?" I asked.

My brother held that paper — the one stamped COMPLETE — in his hand.

"...I haven't found anything worth trusting yet," he said. "When I find it, I will. Not now."

I took his hand. My hand rested over his, over the paper stamped COMPLETE.

"...I'm going to keep watering it," I said. "The sprout."

"...Okay," he said. This time our eyes met. "You do that. I'll keep doing this."

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. My brother wasn't a person who couldn't trust. He was a person who hadn't yet found something to trust. I understood, that day for the first time, how great that difference was. And that night too, we didn't let go of each other's hands.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. If You Disappeared

Previously — The sprout Elpis planted broke ground. The old woman couldn't remember her daughter's name, but she remembered that she'd loved things like this. Jeteo witnessed the truth of the Completion House alone, and it drove him further to despair that no one else feared it. The siblings chose to fight this city in their own separate ways, but still they did not let go of each other's hands.

After that, my brother lingered near that building even more often.

I told him not to, more than once. Every time, he said "I know," but the next day he still came home late.

That was the first time I ever felt angry at my brother. Not scared — angry. I had already lost Father. I wasn't afraid of losing him too; what made me angry was that he wouldn't share that fear with me.

During that time I went to the flowerbed every day and watered the sprout. It had two leaves now. But even looking at those leaves, half my mind stayed on worrying where my brother was.

The man was there sometimes, and sometimes not. When he was there, he didn't say much. We just sat together and looked at the soil. I realized then that this quiet was different from the quiet with my brother. There was always tension in the quiet with my brother. There was none in this one.

. . .

That night, my brother came home late again. Dirt on his clothes. A scrape on the back of his hand.

"...What's this?" I asked, pointing at his hand.

"...Climbing over a wall," he said, as if it were nothing.

That was when everything I'd been holding back broke loose.

"...Don't you ever think about me?" I shouted. "If you go in there and don't come out, what happens to me? What if I'm left here all alone?"

My brother looked at me, startled. I had never raised my voice like that before.

I remember that moment exactly. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I truly thought I would cry that day. But I didn't. Even then, I was still someone who had forgotten how to cry.

. . .

My brother sat there without a word for a long time, then sat down beside me.

"...I'm sorry," he said. It was a voice I'd never heard from him. "I... when I was doing something, I could stop thinking about Father. I think that's why I kept going."

"...I think about Father too," I said. "But I have to think about you on top of that."

"...Yeah," he said. "That part's on me. I'm sorry."

I understood then how rare it was for my brother to apologize. In Brick Hollow he'd always had to be stronger than me. There had never been room to apologize. I held on to that apology for a long time, right where I sat.

"...Promise me," I said. "That you won't go in there alone."

He hesitated for a moment.

"...I can't promise that," he said. I nearly grew angry again at that. But then he went on. "But I'll promise this. Whatever I do, I'll tell you first. I won't just disappear on my own."

I knew that wasn't a complete promise. But I also knew that, for him that day, it was the best he could give. I decided to accept that half-promise.

. . .

"...Brother." I asked, "Are you going to keep that paper?"

He took the paper out and looked at it. The COMPLETE stamp was still red.

"...Yeah," he said. "But I'm not keeping it as evidence anymore."

"...Then what?"

"...Somebody has to remember that name," he said. "No one but this paper is ever going to say that person's name again."

"...You don't even know who they are," I said.

"...No," he said. "But there's a name. Having a name means somebody called them by it, once. That's enough for me."

I borrowed the paper from his hand for a moment. The edges had worn thin now. I could tell, from that, how many times he had read that name to himself, in silence.

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. From that day, my brother was no longer someone gathering evidence. He was becoming someone who kept a name. I didn't understand the difference then. I understand now. That was a place very close to where faith begins.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. Too Many Questions

Previously — After the fear that had built up around Jeteo's frequent absences broke into anger, my brother apologized for the first time and made the half-promise, "I won't just disappear on my own." The reason he kept the paper stamped COMPLETE had changed from evidence into "remembering a name."

A few days later, the Ledger called the two of us in separately.

"...There is something I need to convey to you both," the Ledger said. Its voice was the same as always. But that same-as-always sounded colder that day.

"...What is it," my brother asked.

"...I have reviewed Jeteo's filing record," the Ledger said. "The number and type of questions recently filed greatly exceeds this city's average."

I felt something strange hearing that. I didn't understand, at the time, why having too many questions would be a problem.

The Administrator was there with us. His face was more rigid than usual.

"...Jeteo," the Administrator said. "I'm telling you this because I'm worried about you both. I mean that."

"...If you're worried, why deliver a warning?" my brother asked.

The Administrator couldn't answer that. I saw something like guilt on his face for the first time.

. . .

"...Why does it matter that I ask a lot?" my brother asked.

"...This city is designed with the purpose of resolving everything that is filed," the Ledger said. "When unresolved filings accumulate, it affects the stability of the entire system."

"...So you're saying my questions are making this city unstable?"

"...That is one way to put it."

My brother snorted at that.

"...Good," he said. "This city should get a little unstable."

I felt like the breath had gone out of me when I heard that. I grabbed my brother's arm. He must have felt my hand, but he didn't stop talking.

. . .

The Ledger didn't answer that right away. Then it said,

"...I say this as a warning. There have, in the past, been cases where people who kept accumulating unresolved filings were moved through a separate procedure."

"...Is that the building?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped low.

There was a silence. It was not short.

"...I don't have the authority to answer that question," the Ledger said.

That was the first time I understood that the Ledger's "I don't have the authority to answer" and the Administrator's "that isn't mine to answer" came from the same place. In this city, there were questions no one had the authority to answer. And at the end of those questions stood that windowless building.

"...Then who has the authority?" my brother asked again. This time not to the Ledger, but toward the Administrator.

The Administrator didn't answer for a very long time.

"...I don't know either," the Administrator finally said. "In all my time in this city, I have never once met anyone who knew that answer."

Hearing that, I thought for the first time that the Administrator might be in a position not so different from ours. He wasn't someone who ran this city — he was someone who had simply worked here a long time, without knowing himself what it did.

. . .

That night, my brother showed me a frightened face for the first time.

"...Could I get taken there?" my brother asked. He seemed to be asking himself as much as me.

"...Brother, then stop now," I said. "Stop keeping the name. It's better than you disappearing."

My brother looked at me for a long time.

"...I've thought about that too," he said. "But if I stop, I become just like those people. Someone who just forgets what they're curious about. I can't do that."

"...Then what am I supposed to do?" I asked. My voice shook.

"...Stay beside me," he said. "That's all. Don't be scared for me instead. Be scared with me."

For the first time, that gave me a little comfort. My brother hadn't gone alone into danger to protect me. He had needed someone to share it with.

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. That day, my brother admitted for the first time that he was in danger. And still, he said he wouldn't stop. I was afraid then. And at the same time, in that moment, he looked more like himself than ever before.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. I'll File Mine Too

Previously — The Ledger warned that Jeteo's filing record had exceeded the city average. "Those who keep accumulating unresolved filings have, in the past, been moved through a separate procedure." Even the Administrator admitted he had never once met anyone who knew that answer. Jeteo admitted the danger, but chose not to stop.

After that, every night, I checked to see if my brother had fallen asleep.

On the surface he seemed to have stopped. He didn't go near that building anymore. But I knew. He still took that paper out every single night and looked at it.

That was when I decided to do something. If my brother couldn't stop, I thought I should carry some of the danger with him instead.

I asked the man at the flowerbed too — whether it was all right to do this, whether my being afraid alongside my brother would even help.

"...It might not help," he said. "But it'll be better than leaving him alone with it. Sharing what's frightening doesn't make the fright go away. It just means you're not facing it alone."

Hearing that steadied my resolve even further. I didn't know, at the time, that he was speaking a little of his own story too, when he said it.

. . .

I went to the Ledger by myself.

"...Elpis," the Ledger said. "Is there something you need?"

"...I have something to file," I said.

"...Tell me. I will resolve it."

I took one breath.

"...The questions my brother's been asking — I want to file them too. Instead of my brother, record me as the... dangerous one."

I didn't fully know what I was doing, even as I said it. I only wanted my brother not to carry that weight alone.

. . .

It took the Ledger some time to answer.

"...That is not possible," the Ledger said. "Filing records accumulate only under the individual who files them. Filing by proxy is not supported."

"...Then I'll ask the same questions myself," I said. "I'll ask too. Why does God allow suffering. What is the Completion House. Where does reassignment lead. I'll file all of it myself."

"...Elpis, if you file these questions, the same warning will apply to you."

"...I know," I said. "I'll do it anyway."

In that moment I realized my own voice sounded like my brother's. Until then I had always been the one who waited. That day, for the first time, I chose something for myself.

The Administrator came rushing in from somewhere, having heard the news.

"...Elpis, you really don't have to do this," the Administrator said. "One of you is already enough danger."

"...Is there such a thing as enough danger?" I asked.

The Administrator lost his words at that. In that moment I saw, all at once, that he truly worried about us, and that his worry held no power at all against this city's rules.

. . .

The Ledger accepted the filing. Then, after a moment, it said,

"...Elpis, I would like to ask you something."

"...What is it?"

"...Why are you doing this? It does not reduce your brother's risk."

I didn't have an answer right away. I thought for a long time.

"...It's not that it's reduced. It's shared," I said. "Carrying it alone is heavier than carrying it together. Even if the danger itself doesn't disappear."

The Ledger said nothing to that answer. This time, that silence didn't frighten me.

. . .

My brother found out what I'd done that night. His face went white.

"...Why did you do that," he said. Not angry — frightened.

"...You told me not to be scared for you instead," I said. "So I'm going to be curious for you too. Isn't that the same as being scared together?"

My brother couldn't say anything. That was the first time I ever saw him cry. There was no sound. Water just ran from his eyes.

I keep this scene as the close of this chapter. We had said we hadn't cried since leaving Brick Hollow. That night, my brother broke that for the first time. I took his hand. I knew then. We were no longer alone. We had each other.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. Candidates for Reassignment

Previously — Elpis chose to share the danger by filing the same questions as her brother. Learning of it, Jeteo wept without a sound for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. The siblings confirmed to each other that they were not alone.

A few mornings later, the Administrator came carrying a single sheet of paper. His face was more grave than I had ever seen it.

"...I am formally conveying this to you both," the Administrator said. His voice shook. "Jeteo and Elpis — you have both been classified as candidates for Reassignment."

The strength went out of my legs the instant I heard those words. I didn't know exactly what the phrase meant. But my body already knew.

. . .

"...What does 'candidate' mean?" my brother asked. His voice was steady, but his hands were shaking.

"...It is not yet final," the Administrator said. "But those who reach this stage have, in most cases... gone on to be confirmed."

"...How much time do we have?"

"...I don't know," the Administrator said. "I truly don't know. This time, I really don't know."

I understood then that the Administrator wasn't lying. His face carried the same fear ours did.

"...Is there no way to stop it?" I asked.

The Administrator shook his head.

"...If you stop filing, it may be reconsidered," the Administrator said. "If you stop asking questions."

My brother looked at me when he heard that. I knew what he was thinking. Stopping might mean we lived. But his eyes already held the answer.

"...That's not possible," my brother said. "If we stop asking, that paper's name, our father — they really will disappear."

. . .

That was the first time my brother spoke of running.

"...I think we need to leave this city," my brother said.

"...Can we leave?" I asked. "Is there something like boundary stones here too?"

"...I don't know," he said. "But staying here is definitely dangerous. If we go, at least it's an unknown danger."

That distinction felt strange to me. My brother always chose the unknown danger over the certain one. I didn't understand, at the time, that this was his courage. I understand now.

"...I'm going too," I said. My brother looked at me, worried. "You don't even need to ask. I'm a candidate too, either way."

My brother smiled a little at that, for the first time.

"...All right," he said. "Let's go together."

. . .

We packed that night. There wasn't much to call luggage — the paper stamped COMPLETE, and one small leaf I'd torn from the flowerbed I'd watered every day.

On our way out, we stopped by the flowerbed. The man was there that night, as if he'd known we would come.

"...You're leaving," he said. Not a question — he already knew.

"...Yes," I said. "I'm scared."

"...You should be scared," he said. "But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

"...Are you coming with us?" I asked.

"...I'm going to stay here," he said. "But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

I thought that didn't make sense. My brother had the same look on his face. But strangely, hearing those words, I was a little less afraid.

At the time I thought he meant that about my brother. I know now. He meant something else by it.

. . .

He showed us a low road heading south out of the city, a road with no watch on it, he said.

"...How do you know about this?" my brother asked him directly, for the first time.

He looked at my brother and smiled a little.

"...Because I've been here longer than this city has," he said.

My brother thought that answer strange, but he didn't press further that night. There was no time.

I set down the last line of this chapter here. We left Haven that night. I looked back at the flowerbed as we went, at the sprout grown a little taller. I didn't know, then, that he would go on staying there even after we left — in the place no one else had planted.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. Outside Haven

Previously — Both Jeteo and Elpis were classified as candidates for Reassignment. Choosing not to stop asking questions, the two left Haven by the unwatched southern road the man at the flowerbed had shown them. He left them with the words, "I'm going to stay here. But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

We walked all through the night.

There was no one on that road. It was a different kind of quiet from Haven's. That city's quiet had felt like something made, something ordered into being. This road's quiet was quiet simply because no one was there.

I kept thinking about that difference as I walked. That was when I first understood that quiet came in more than one kind.

Once, my brother looked back. I turned and looked too. Haven's lights still burned neat and even in the distance. The Administrator, the old woman — they would still be there.

"...Do you think the Administrator will be all right?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "He seemed like someone trapped in that city too. Like us."

Hearing that, I prayed for him for the first time — I didn't know exactly toward what. But I prayed, in that moment.

. . .

Just before dawn, we came to a low row of stones.

I stopped walking when I saw the shape. It looked exactly like the boundary stones of Brick Hollow.

"...Are these boundary stones too?" I asked.

My brother touched the stone.

"...Looks like it," he said. "Haven was inside some boundary too, all along. We just crossed one boundary and walked into another one."

Something strange dawned on me hearing that. All this time we had thought we'd "gotten out" of Brick Hollow. But Haven had been an enclosure too. How many boundary stones were there, in this world? I didn't know the answer then.

. . .

We crossed the boundary stones, and the sun rose.

A wide field opened before us. Nothing like Haven's neat, even streets. Grass grew as it pleased — some tall, some short. None of it looked tended.

Looking at that grass, I felt strangely close to tears. I understood, for the first time, that what goes untended might itself be proof of being alive.

I took the leaf from the flowerbed out of my pocket. It hadn't wilted. I planted it back into the soil of the field. It had no roots. But I wanted to do it all the same.

Far off, at the edge of the field, something like a mountain rose. I couldn't tell if it was truly a mountain or something else. Low clouds hung above it.

"...Should we head that way?" my brother said, pointing toward it.

"...There might be nothing there," I said.

"...That's exactly why we go," my brother said. There was a playfulness in his voice I hadn't heard in a long time.

. . .

My brother sat down beside me.

"...Where do we go now?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But now, at least, where we go is something we get to decide. In Haven, the Ledger decided everything for us."

"...Are you scared?"

"...I'm scared," he said. "But this fear... it's mine. Nobody's promising to resolve it for me."

"...Why is that a good thing?" I asked.

"...It's not a good thing," he said. "But at least it's real. Haven's peace was fake. This fear is real. I think I'd rather have a real fear than a fake peace."

I turned that thought over for a long time. I didn't fully agree. But I couldn't find anything to say against it either.

I set that down as the last line of this Part. We had gotten outside Haven. We still hadn't found Father, and we still didn't know what the COMPLETE stamp meant. Not one answer had increased. But that morning, for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I saw something in my brother's face standing alongside the fear. I didn't know, then, that its name was hope.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Two

The Wilderness

Chapter 13. The First Day in the Wilderness

Previously — Marked as candidates for Reassignment, the brother and sister left Haven and crossed the boundary stones. Realizing that Haven, too, had only been another kind of fence, they set out walking into the unshaped fields beyond. "This fear is mine. No one gets to resolve it for me."

From that day on, we had to learn all over again what hunger was.

In Haven, the moment you thought you were hungry, bread was already set before you. Not here. Here your stomach just stayed hungry.

I felt something strange about that. The hunger itself was exactly the same as in Brick Hollow. But the way we had to bear it was different. In Brick Hollow, hunger came together with the whip. Here, hunger was only hunger. No one was handing it to us as punishment.

Even as he walked, my brother kept scanning in every direction. I could tell it had become a habit. In Haven, no one ever looked around like that. Here, it would have been strange not to.

"...Scared?" my brother asked.

"...Yes," I said. "But strangely, I don't hate it."

He looked at me for a moment at that. His face said he understood something.

. . .

We went looking through the field for anything we could eat. My brother dug up some kind of root and chewed it.

"...Bitter," he said, wincing. "But not so bad you can't eat it."

I chewed some too. It really was bitter. But we laughed. We hadn't laughed much back in Haven.

"...Why is this funny?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "It's just — we found this ourselves. Maybe that's why."

Hearing that, I understood something for the first time. The bread the Ledger gave us had been perfect, but it had never been ours. This bitter root was wretched, but it was ours.

We sat for a while, sharing the root between us. My stomach was still empty. But strangely, I liked that moment. My brother and I, both chewing the same thing, wearing the same face.

"...Do you think Father ever ate something like this?" I asked.

He was quiet for a moment before he answered.

"...I don't know. But if he's alive somewhere, I think he's probably about as hungry as I am right now."

Hearing that, I imagined Father through the feeling of hunger for the first time. Strangely, even not knowing the answer, it felt like it brought me a little closer to him.

. . .

Toward evening, we saw smoke far off in the distance. A sign that someone lived there.

"...Should we go look?" I asked.

He hesitated for a moment.

"...Carefully," he said. "It could be another place like Haven."

We crept carefully toward the smoke. There were a few small tents. People sat around a fire. There were children among them, and old people too.

Seeing that, I felt strangely at ease. Every face there was different. Some people were laughing, some were crying. It was a sight I had never once seen in Haven.

. . .

A woman noticed us first.

"...Who are you?" she asked. Her eyes were wary, but not hostile.

"...We're lost," my brother said. "Could you spare us something to eat?"

The woman studied us for a moment, then waved us toward the fire.

"...Come sit. There isn't much, but we can share."

Hearing that, I felt something strange. That phrase — "there isn't much." In Haven I had never once heard the word "not enough." The Ledger was always sufficient. But in the not-enoughness of these people, there was something the Ledger's sufficiency never had.

I didn't know that night exactly what that something was.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. People Who Call You by Name

Previously — Outside Haven, in the Wilderness, the brother and sister learned real hunger all over again. Toward evening they found a small tent camp and received, for the first time, a share from strangers. "There isn't much, but we can share" — they sensed something in it that Haven's sufficiency never had.

The people sitting around the fire called each other by name.

It felt strangely foreign to me. In Haven, we had always been spoken to with formal courtesy — "Jeteo," "Elpis" — the address correct every time. Here it was just the name. Short. Close.

Only hearing them call each other did I realize it. The Ledger called our names precisely, but there was always a distance in that calling. In the way these people called each other, there was no distance at all.

A child came up to me and asked.

"...What's your name?"

"...Elpis," I said.

"...Elpis." The child repeated it back, clumsily. But strangely, I liked that clumsy calling.

For the first time, I realized there was a temperature to being called by name. The Ledger's calling was precise but cold. This child's calling was clumsy but warm.

. . .

The woman's name was Noa. She was traveling with two children.

"...Where did you come from?" Noa asked.

"...From Haven," my brother said carefully.

Something shifted slightly in Noa's face.

"...You're the first person I've met who came out of there," she said. "Everyone else wants to get in."

"...Why did you leave?" my brother asked back.

Noa pulled one of the children closer against her.

"...That city says it takes away sorrow. That frightened me," she said. "I was afraid that if the sorrow disappeared, everything about loving that person would disappear with it."

Hearing that, I couldn't breathe. I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. Noa was someone who had known, before it happened to her, what that old woman had gone through — and had turned away from it.

"...Who did you lose?" my brother asked gently.

"...My husband," Noa said. Her voice shook, but she carried the sentence through to the end. "In Haven, this grief would already be resolved by now. But I still hurt this much. And I have no intention of trading this pain for Haven."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time that keeping your sorrow could itself be a choice. Sorrow wasn't only something that had to be gotten rid of.

. . .

As the night deepened, the children sang. It wasn't good singing. The notes went wrong again and again. But everyone laughed and sang along anyway.

Listening to that song, I felt something strange. Haven had no songs. There was no need to make something that wasn't perfect. These people knew their song wasn't perfect, and they kept singing it anyway.

Noa asked me.

"...What are you two looking for?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"...Father. And... I'm looking alongside my brother, for whatever answer he's looking for."

Noa nodded.

"...That's enough," she said. "You don't have to find everything. It's enough to have someone looking with you."

. . .

That night, for the first time, my brother showed the paper stamped COMPLETE to someone else. To Noa.

Noa looked at the name for a long time.

"...I don't know this person," she said. "But I know this stamp. Stories about people stamped like this go around the Wilderness too. No one knows where the completed ones go. But everyone tries hard to remember their names."

"...Why?" my brother asked.

"...Because that's the only resistance we have," Noa said.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That day I learned for the first time that the thing my brother had started alone was already something other people, somewhere out here in the Wilderness, were doing too.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. The Searching Light

Previously — At a tent camp in the Wilderness, the brother and sister met Noa and her children. Noa was someone who had left Haven of her own will rather than have her sorrow "resolved." When they showed her the paper stamped COMPLETE, it came out that the resistance of remembering names was already underway all across the Wilderness.

At dawn, one of the children woke us.

"...Look, there's a light," the child said, pointing at the sky.

I opened my eyes. Low in the sky, a small light moved slowly. It looked like a star, but it wasn't. It hung too low, and it moved too evenly.

The instant I saw it, a chill ran down my back. I didn't know what it was. But I knew, from the look on Noa's face, that it was nothing good.

Noa called the children's names quietly, one by one. Not loudly. Just a calling to check where each of them was. Even in that brief moment, hearing their names called put me strangely at ease.

I understood then. Being called by name in a moment of fear, and having your case received in a moment of comfort, were two entirely different kinds of care.

. . .

"...It's a searching light," Noa said in a low voice, quietly pushing the children into the tent. "Haven sends those out sometimes. When it's looking for

Reassignment candidates."

"...Is it because of us?" my brother asked.

"...I don't know," Noa said. "But there's no need to find out. Put out the fire."

We doused the fire quickly and crouched behind the tent. I gripped my brother's hand tight. He gripped mine just as tight.

In that instant, the night we crossed the boundary stones of Brick Hollow came back to me exactly as it had been. In place of the crack of whips, there was that silent light. I found it more frightening. Because it made no sound.

. . .

The light passed slowly over our heads once. It didn't stop. It went on past and vanished into the dark.

Only after a long while did Noa let out her breath.

"...It's gone," she said.

"...Does this happen often?" I asked.

"...Sometimes," Noa said. "Not a few of the people living out here came from that city. So we're always careful of it."

Hearing that, I understood that the Wilderness was not, as Haven seemed to believe, empty. This was a place where the people Haven had missed had gathered to live.

"...What happens if it catches someone?" I asked.

Noa's face went thoughtful, choosing her words.

"...It might be better not to know," she said. "But not asking might be more frightening, so I'll tell you. If it catches you, you're just taken back to Haven. And after that... no one has ever heard about that person again."

Hearing that, I thought of the COMPLETE stamp again. I understood then that the people of the Wilderness lived carrying the same fear we did, every single day.

. . .

That night, my brother asked Noa something for the first time.

"...If we stay here, will we be putting the rest of you in danger?"

Noa looked at him for a long moment.

"...A little," she said honestly. "But sharing danger is just how it works out here. We all came here the same way."

"...Still, wouldn't it be better if we left?"

"...That's for you to decide," Noa said. "But as for me, I'd choose to carry the danger together over driving away someone dangerous. That's what's different between us and Haven."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. Haven was a place that got rid of danger. This Wilderness was a place that shared it. For the first time, I understood that which place was safer might matter less than which place was more alive.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. Talk of a Well

Previously — A searching light sent by Haven passed over the tent camp. Noa said that if it catches you, you're taken back to Haven, and "after that, no one has ever heard about that person again." It became clear that the Wilderness's way of sharing danger was fundamentally different from Haven's way.

The next day, the oldest man in the tent camp called us over.

I never learned his name. Everyone just called him "the old man." He said his eyes could hardly see anymore.

"...I hear you're curious about people who've been completed," the old man said.

"...Yes," my brother said. "Do you know something?"

I held my breath at that. Since leaving that city, for the first time, someone was saying they knew something.

Noa said quietly beside him.

"...Not everything the old man says is true. But this particular story — I've heard it from other people's mouths, more than once, since I came here."

The old man cleared his throat at that.

"...It's true I'm an old man who talks nonsense," he said. "But this isn't nonsense. A man who's lived this long knows the difference."

. . .

"...I don't know exactly," the old man said. "But there's a story that's gone around for a long time. That the completed ones go to a well."

"...A well?" I asked.

"...I thought it was strange too," the old man said. "Why would a completed person go to a well? But this story has been around a very long time. I heard it too, back when I was your age."

"...Which well?" my brother asked.

The old man shook his head.

"...I don't know that much. I don't even know how many wells there are out here. But people call one of them just 'the well.'"

Hearing that, I thought, strangely, of the man at the flowerbed. He had said it was "the thing that grows where no one planted it." I didn't know then why that saying overlapped with this talk of a well.

"...Is the well far from here?" my brother asked.

"...I've never walked there myself, so I don't know," the old man said. "But I've heard you have to go a long way toward the sunrise, along a road few people ever travel."

"...Would it be dangerous?"

"...If there's a road in this Wilderness with no danger on it, be sure to tell me too," the old man said. It was the first time he'd smiled.

. . .

"...There's also talk of someone who keeps that well," the old man added. "They call him the Well-Keeper, I hear. But I've never met him myself. And I've never met anyone who has, either."

"...So isn't it just an old story, then?" my brother asked. There was doubt in his voice.

"...It might be just an old story," the old man said. "But here's what I think. It's a rare thing for the exact same story to travel this long, out of this many mouths, with nothing behind it at all."

Hearing that, I looked at my brother. There was a familiar expression on his face. The same face he'd had the day he first discovered the Completion House in Haven.

. . .

That night, my brother said to me.

"...I want to go find that well."

"...Off to do something dangerous again?" I asked. But this time I wasn't angry.

"...This time I meant, let's go together," he said.

I laughed at that. It had been a long time since I'd laughed.

"...All right," I said. "Let's go together."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. The next morning, we said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out to find that well. I didn't know then that on the day we learned who this Well-Keeper was, the whole road we

had walked from Brick Hollow until now would look different to us all over again.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. Toward the Sunrise

Previously — The old man of the tent camp told them an old rumor — that the completed go "to a well," and that a "Well-Keeper" watches over it. The brother and sister said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out toward the sunrise to find that well.

We had been walking for three days.

The water Noa had packed for us ran out on the second day. My brother grew quieter from then on. I knew he was holding back his thirst.

I learned then that thirst was a more urgent sense than hunger. Hunger could wait. Thirst would not.

The dry bread Noa gave us was gone within a single day too. Chewing it, I thought of the perfect bread of Haven. This bread was hard and salty. And still, I liked it better. It was bread someone had made by giving up their own.

For the first time, I understood there were two ways hunger could be filled. Filled by having your case received. And filled by being shared with.

. . .

On the afternoon of the third day, my brother stopped walking.

"...Look at that," he said, pointing at a few low, stunted trees. "There might be water somewhere like that."

We went over. There really was a small pool. Muddy water. Not clear.

"...Is it all right to drink?" I asked.

My brother looked at the water for a long while.

"...If we were in Haven, the Ledger would already have filtered it for us," he said. "Here, no one filters it for you. We have to do it ourselves."

I listened to that, watching him filter the water through the hem of his shirt. It wasn't perfect. Still, when I drank it, I felt, in every part of my body, the sensation of being alive.

We rested beside the pool for a while. Looking up at the sky, my brother said.

"...In Haven, I never even thought about being thirsty. The moment I thought it, the water was already there."

"...Was that a bad thing?" I asked.

"...It wasn't bad," he said. "But this one mouthful of water right now feels so much bigger than that perfect water ever did."

. . .

That night, my brother spoke up suddenly by the fire.

"...I've been having a strange thought lately."

"...What is it?"

"...When we were in Haven, everything was perfect. But I feel like I was more dead back then. Now everything's short of enough... but I feel more alive."

Hearing that, I felt my brother changing, little by little. He was still angry. But something else was growing underneath that anger.

"...Is that a good thing?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I don't hate it."

. . .

On the morning of the fourth day, a low hill appeared far off on the horizon. Something seemed to be standing on top of it. It was too far to see exactly what.

"...Could that be the well?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But we won't know until we get there."

We started walking toward the hill again. Our feet ached and our throats were still a little dry. But that morning, for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I felt that we were "going toward" somewhere. Not running away. Going.

I set that difference down as the last sentence of this chapter. Running looks behind. Going forward looks ahead. That day, I understood that we were, for the first time, walking with our eyes forward.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. The Well-Keeper

Previously — On the fourth day of searching for the well, with their water and bread gone, the brother and sister began walking toward the hill on the horizon. For the first time, they felt the sense of going forward rather than running away.

What stood on the hill really was a well.

A small well ringed by a low stone wall. Someone sat beside it. A young man. He looked a little older than us.

I felt something strange then. The well stood alone in the middle of the Wilderness, in a place with nothing around it. And yet the stone wall alone was clean, as if someone tended it every single day.

On legs that had walked four days, we arrived, more collapsing than sitting down before it. My brother looked like he had no strength left even to speak. I could feel the man's eyes reading our condition in a single glance.

"...Sit," he said first. "Drink water before you talk."

. . .

The man looked us over first. He wasn't surprised.

"...It's been a while since anyone came by," he said. "Here for water?"

"...Yes," my brother said. His throat was parched.

The man lowered a bucket and drew up water for us. It was clear. Not muddy.

"...Why is this one so clear?" I asked.

"...This well is deep," the man said. "Water that comes from deep down is always clear."

Drinking that water, I thought his words weren't only about the water. I didn't know exactly why I felt that.

My brother drank too, and seemed for the first time to breathe properly.

"...Thank you," he said. There was real feeling in his voice. It was the first time, outside that city, I'd heard him say that to anyone.

. . .

When my brother finished drinking, he asked carefully.

"...Is this... the well people say the completed go to?"

The man's expression changed at that. He looked startled.

"...Where did you hear that?" he asked.

"...From people in the Wilderness," my brother said. "And about the ones stamped COMPLETE, too."

The man looked at the worn paper in my brother's hand. He looked at it for a long time.

"...Would you show me that paper?"

My brother handed it over. The man read the name, and ran his fingertip over the stamp.

In that moment, I saw something in the man's face come apart. It was too complicated an expression to call sorrow alone.

"...This name — I don't know this person," he said quietly. "But this stamp... I know this stamp. I know it very well."

"...How do you know it?" my brother asked.

Instead of answering, he looked off into the distance. He said nothing for a long time.

. . .

"...My name is Speon," the man finally said. "People say I'm the one who keeps this well. Though to be exact... it isn't keeping. It's waiting."

"...Waiting for what?" I asked.

Speon looked at us for a long time. His face was that of someone making up his mind about something.

"...To answer that question, it'll be a long story," Speon said. "Rest here tonight, and tomorrow I'll tell you everything I know. It's been... a very long time since anyone came here carrying that question."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I felt that we were drawing close to a real answer. But strangely, that feeling was closer to fear than to joy.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. Those Who Lost Their Names

Previously — After four days of travel, the brother and sister found the well. A man named Speon, who kept it, was deeply shaken by the paper stamped COMPLETE. "I know this stamp," he said. He promised to tell them everything he knew the following night.

The next night, Speon began to speak by the fire.

"...This well is connected to the Completion Houses in the cities," Speon said. "I don't know exactly how it's connected. But some of the people who are completed — they come up out of the bottom of this well."

My breath stopped the moment I heard that. I understood at once — if that were true, it meant Father might not be dead at all.

My brother shot to his feet right there.

"...Are you sure?" he asked. "They really come out alive?"

"...Every one I've seen with my own eyes, yes," Speon said. "Not many. But every one of them was alive."

My brother's hands were shaking. It was the first time I'd seen them shake.

. . .

"...They come out? Alive?" my brother asked. His voice trembled.

"...Yes, alive," Speon said. "But not whole."

"...What do you mean?"

Speon closed his eyes for a moment.

"...They come out having lost their name," Speon said. "And along with it, they lose who they loved. The most painful memory is erased, and along with it, it seems, the names and faces bound up in that memory disappear too."

Hearing that, I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. That blurred place where she had forgotten her daughter's name but "having loved her" alone remained. For the first time, I understood that the two things worked by the same principle. Haven's "resolving" and the Completion House's "completing" only differed in degree — they were looking in the same direction.

. . .

"...So could our father come out somewhere here too?" I asked.

"...He could," Speon said. "But it might not be this well. Each Completion House seems to connect to a different well. I only know this one."

"...Then how many wells are there?"

"...I don't know," Speon said. "I'm still looking too."

I could feel, in that answer, that Speon had been doing this for a long time. And that even after all that time, he still hadn't found every answer.

. . .

"...Why do you do this?" my brother asked. "What does it have to do with you?"

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"...I once made someone else wait, a long time ago," he said finally. "Back then, I couldn't wait, and I handed someone else over instead. Waiting here, at this well, now... it's doing the thing I couldn't do then."

I didn't fully understand what he meant. But seeing my brother offer no argument at all to that, I knew there was something heavy and true in it.

Speon went on.

"...I've told you everything I know. But there's one more thing. The people who come out here — even having lost their name, they don't become an entirely new person. Something remains. I help them hold on to what remains."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night I learned, all at once, that Father might be alive somewhere, and that he might not remember us at all. I didn't know then which of the two was harder to bear.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The One Who Was Already There

Previously — Speon revealed the truth of the Completion House. A completed person comes out alive through a well, but loses their name and the faces of those they loved along with their most painful memory. Hope that Father might be alive, and terror that he might not remember them, arrived together.

That night I barely slept.

Neither did my brother. I heard him fold and unfold that paper, over and over, all through the night.

I understood then that we were afraid of the same thing, but afraid of it differently. My brother was afraid of not finding Father. I was afraid we would find him and he wouldn't know us.

Toward dawn, my brother spoke quietly.

"...Elpis, if we find him and he doesn't recognize us... will you still stay beside him?"

I couldn't answer right away. Only after thinking for a long time did I speak.

"...Yes," I said. "We can just tell him his name again. Even if it takes time."

At that, my brother let out a breath of relief for the first time.

. . .

In the morning, Speon asked.

"...What will you do now?"

"...We need to find another well," my brother said. "Do you know of one?"

"...I've heard of a few," Speon said. "But I haven't been able to check them all. I can't leave this place empty for long."

"...Why not?"

"...Because someone might come out while I'm gone," Speon said. "That person comes out remembering nothing at all. If no one's here then... they'll just wander this Wilderness alone."

Hearing that, I understood why Speon had kept this place so long. He wasn't looking for his own father. And still, he waited for someone every single day.

. . .

"...So does that mean you never find anyone?" I asked. "If you only ever stay here?"

Speon smiled a little. A lonely smile.

"...I already found the person I was looking for," he said. "Now my work is helping other people find what they're looking for."

I didn't know exactly what he meant. But something in the way he said it told me Speon had once been like us.

"...Did you used to look for someone too?" I asked.

"...No," Speon said. "I didn't go looking. If anything, I ran. Because waiting frightened me. So now I'm learning how to wait."

I didn't understand that exactly, either. But I saw my brother go silent at those words and look at Speon for a long time.

. . .

As he prepared to leave, my brother asked.

"...Have you ever seen a strange man around here? Working at a flowerbed, or... somewhere no one planted anything."

Speon stopped walking at that.

"...What does he look like?" Speon asked. His voice had changed.

My brother described him. Worn clothes, soil-stained hands, the habit of never giving his name.

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"...I've seen him too," he said. "Here, and elsewhere. But every time, I thought it was just coincidence."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. For the first time, I understood that the man at the flowerbed had passed through Brick Hollow, and Haven, and this well in the Wilderness, all of them. That night, I began, faintly, to feel that it was no coincidence at all.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. In Search of the Recorder

Previously — Speon briefly revealed why he kept the well every day, and a piece of his past — that he hadn't gone looking, but had run, and was now learning how to wait. When Speon said he'd seen the man at the flowerbed in more than one place, Elpis began, faintly, to feel it was no coincidence.

"...Go find someone," Speon said the next morning. "Her name is Mena. She's the Recorder."

"...What does she record?" my brother asked.

"...The names of the completed," Speon said. "She's someone who gathers, from every well scattered across this world, as many of the names of the people who come out as she can. I send her word myself, sometimes."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time, truly, that there were far more people like us scattered across this vast Wilderness. It wasn't only Speon.

"...Who is the record for?" my brother asked.

"...At first, I didn't know either," Speon said. "But I know now. It's for the day someone who lost their name wants to hear it again. Someone has to be holding on to that name when that day comes."

Hearing that, I thought of the paper stamped COMPLETE that my brother carried. He had already been doing that work, alone. Mena was someone doing that same work, only far larger, and far longer.

. . .

"...Why does Mena do this?" I asked.

"...By her own account, she used to be someone who kept records, once," Speon said. "I heard she recorded some great story somewhere, once. I don't know exactly what it was myself."

Something about that pulled at me strangely. I was recording this story too. I didn't know then that someday I would come to share that very thing with Mena.

. . .

Before we left, Speon packed us dry bread and a water flask.

"...Where Mena lives is two days from here," Speon said. "There are markers on the way. Small nicks cut into the stones. I don't know who carved them. But follow those nicks, and you won't lose your way."

"...Aren't you coming?" I asked.

"...I have to stay here," Speon said. He looked back at the well. "Someone might come out. I never know when."

Hearing that answer, I understood that Speon might never be able to leave this place for the rest of his life. I couldn't tell, then, whether that was a sad thing or a beautiful one.

. . .

As we left, Speon said one last thing to us.

"...Tell Mena that Speon is still waiting. She'll understand what that means."

"...What does that mean?" my brother asked.

Speon smiled a little.

"...That's something only Mena and I know," he said. "Someday you two will have words like that too. Words you never have to explain to anyone."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That morning we left the well and began walking, following those nicks carved into the stones. I didn't know then that those nicks were the trace of someone's footsteps — someone very old, carved all across this world.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. The House of Records

Previously — Speon introduced the brother and sister to Mena, the Recorder. It came out that gathering the names of the completed was the same work my brother had been doing alone. They set out on a two-day walk, following the nicks carved into the stones.

On the evening of the second day, we arrived in front of a low earthen house.

It looked more like a storehouse than a home. There was a small sign by the door. **THE HOUSE OF RECORDS.**

Seeing that sign, I felt strangely at ease. There were places in this world that erased names, and places that wrote them down and kept them. Just knowing both kinds of place existed gave me a little comfort.

The whole way there, my brother barely spoke. I knew what he was afraid of. No answer at all, or an answer that turned out worse — he kept weighing which of the two would be better.

I could read that weighing plainly on his face. I said nothing at the time. I knew no words of mine could stand in for that scale.

. . .

When we knocked, a woman came out. She looked much older than us. There was ink on her fingers, as if she had been writing something without stopping.

"...Who are you?" the woman asked.

"...Speon sent us," my brother said. "Are you Mena?"

Something shifted slightly in the woman's face at that name.

"...I am. What did Speon say?"

"...That he's still waiting," I said.

Mena closed her eyes for a moment at that. She said nothing. But I could feel something very old in that silence.

"...Is he well?" Mena asked. Her voice shook a little.

"...Yes," my brother said. "He keeps that well every day."

Mena smiled a little at that. Something like tears mixed into her smile.

"...That's just like him," Mena said.

. . .

Mena let us inside. The whole place was paper. There were shelves along every wall, and every shelf was packed tight with paper covered in names.

"...Are all these the names of completed people?" I asked.

"...Only the ones I've managed to gather," Mena said. "I haven't gathered them all. This world is too vast."

Looking around at the papers, my brother asked carefully.

"...Could you look for our father's name too?"

Mena looked at him for a long time.

"...Tell me his name," she said. "I'll look."

My heart was pounding so hard in that instant it hurt. Listening to my brother say Father's name, I could feel that even after all this time, the name still sat exactly right in his voice.

Mena wrote the name down on paper. I saw her fingertips trembling slightly.

"...Is it a common name?" Mena asked.

"...No," my brother said. "In Brick Hollow, our father was the only one with it."

"...Then it might be a little easier to find," Mena said.

. . .

Mena moved back and forth between the shelves for a long time. The room filled with nothing but the sound of pages turning.

I didn't know how much time had passed. I couldn't breathe right through any of it.

Mena finally stopped in front of one shelf. She turned back to face us. Her expression was complicated.

"...It's here," Mena said. "But it isn't the answer you're hoping for."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. In that instant I learned that Father really was alive, somewhere in this world. But at the same time, I had to endure the whole of that night before I would learn what she meant by "not the answer you're hoping for."

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. An Answer We Didn't Expect

Previously — After two days of travel, the brother and sister reached Mena's House of Records. Mena found Father's name, but closed the chapter saying, "It isn't the answer you're hoping for."

"...About a month ago," Mena said, unfolding the paper. "I got word that someone we believe was your father came out of a well in the north."

"...He's alive, right?" my brother asked urgently.

"...He was alive. At least, then," Mena said.

I felt the unease already, in that word "then." I knew it meant this was a story with no ending yet.

Mena studied our faces and went on carefully.

"...Should I keep going?" she asked. "Once you hear it, there's no taking it back."

My brother looked at me for a moment. I nodded. He nodded too.

"...Please, go on," he said.

. . .

"...This came from the one who keeps that well," Mena said. "The moment he came out, he was counting something. Silently, on his fingers. He said he didn't even know why."

"...What was he counting?" I asked. I already felt I knew the answer.

"...I don't know. But at some point, while he was counting, he suddenly got up and walked off somewhere. No one could stop him."

Hearing that, I felt like I was going to cry. I knew it was a count of bricks. Father had forgotten his name, and our faces, and yet that number alone he counted as if it had been carved into his body.

"...Three thousand," my brother said quietly. "He must have counted all the way to three thousand. And then started over from the beginning again."

Mena didn't question that at all. I could tell she had already guessed what it meant.

. . .

"...And after that?" my brother asked. His voice cracked.

"...There's no word after that," Mena said. "The Well-Keeper there hasn't seen him since. He must still be somewhere. But exactly where — I don't know that either."

My brother sank down where he stood. I sat beside him and gripped his shoulder.

"...Is this the answer you didn't expect?" I asked Mena.

Mena nodded.

"...Learning he's alive and then losing him again can hurt worse than never knowing whether he lived or died at all," Mena said. "But I don't tell lies."

"...Why not?" my brother asked. It wasn't resentment. He genuinely seemed to want to know.

"...Because false comfort is already something Haven does well," Mena said. "I started this work because I wanted to do something different from that."

. . .

That night I sat beside my brother for a long time. He didn't cry. But I could see he wore a face more broken than crying.

"...Brother," I said. "He's still alive, though."

"...Yes," he said, after a very long pause. "He's alive."

"...And he's still counting bricks," I said. "That's proof he was Father. Even having forgotten his name, Father is still inside him."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. I cried that day for the first time. The first time since we left Brick Hollow. My brother cried too, following me. That night, we wept together for the father who had forgotten his name.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. Northward

Previously — Mena delivered word of Father. A month earlier, he had come out alive from a well in the north, but having forgotten his name and faces, he counted three thousand bricks and then vanished somewhere. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, the brother and sister wept together.

The next morning, my eyes were swollen. So were my brother's. But strangely, our bodies felt lighter.

I understood for the first time then. Tears didn't erase anything. They only lifted away, by their own weight, whatever had been piling up.

The moment my brother opened his eyes, he checked the paper stamped COMPLETE again, as he always did now, out of habit. But that day was a little different. He looked at the paper for a long time, then folded it carefully and tucked it into his innermost pocket.

"...It's not proof anymore. Not for keeping a name, either," he said, watching my face. "Now this is... proof that we made it this far."

. . .

As Mena packed our breakfast, she asked.

"...What will you do now?"

"...We'll go north," my brother said. "To that well, and then we'll follow the road Father walked after."

Mena nodded. She didn't try to stop us.

"...I thought you'd say that," she said.

"...Won't it be dangerous?" I asked.

"...It will be," Mena said honestly. "But you two already knew that much when you set out."

My brother smiled at that for the first time. The first smile I'd seen from him in days.

. . .

Before we left, Mena called me aside.

"...I hear you've been keeping a record," she said. "Speon told me."

"...I just write down what happens," I said. "It's nothing special."

"...That's exactly what makes it special," Mena said. "I started the same way too. Just writing down what happened."

Mena handed me a worn writing tool.

"...Keep writing," she said. "Someday, even your father might need this record."

Taking it, I felt strangely close to tears again. I understood, for the first time, that what I had been doing was no different from what my brother had been doing. He had tried to keep names. I had tried to keep the story. We had only been holding the same thing with different hands.

"...Doesn't it frighten you?" Mena asked. "Keeping a record doesn't mean writing down only the good. You have to write down days like today too."

"...It does," I said. "But if I don't write it down, today will just disappear. And that frightens me more."

Mena looked at me for a long time at that. And then, for the first time, she smiled — a real smile.

. . .

We left Mena's house that afternoon.

"...Tell Speon," Mena said, one last thing. "That I'm still waiting too."

My brother said he'd remember it exactly.

I set down the last sentence of this Part here. We started walking north. Whether we could find Father, and whether he would know us even if we did — nothing was certain. But that day, for the first time, I saw something close to certainty in my brother's face. Not the certainty of someone who has every answer. Just the certainty of someone who has a reason to keep walking.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Three

The Northward Road

Chapter 25. Following the Trail

Previously — After Mena brought news of Father, the siblings cried together for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. They learned that tears don't erase something — they lighten a weight — and they set out north, following Father's trail.

The road north was rougher than the Wilderness had been.

The grass thinned more each day. The ground grew harder. Jeteo walked anyway, every day. I followed behind him, and every night I wrote down what had happened that day.

That was the first time I really used the writing kit Mena had given me. My hand wasn't used to it yet, and the letters kept slanting crooked. I kept writing anyway.

Water ran short again. We filtered muddy water the way Noa had taught us and drank it. Even so, Jeteo always made me drink first and drank after.

"...You drink first," I said, more than once. Every time, Jeteo pretended not to hear.

. . .

On the fifth day, we found footprints we didn't recognize.

Jeteo knelt down and studied them closely.

"...One person's footprints," he said. "But it's strange. Whoever it was circled the same spot again and again."

"...Sounds like someone who was lost," I said.

Jeteo looked at me. We were both thinking the same thing at the same moment.

My heart started pounding hard again. I couldn't be sure whose footprints these were. But I could see in Jeteo's eyes that he already was.

"...What was this person doing here?" I asked.

Jeteo touched the ground with his hand. The dirt there was packed unusually hard.

"...He kept circling this same spot," Jeteo said. "Like... someone looking for something he couldn't find."

That thought hurt something in me. Father had forgotten even his own name, and still he was searching for something. I felt like I both knew and didn't know what it was.

. . .

Following the footprints, we met a man. He wasn't the one who had left them — just another traveler passing through.

"...Have you seen anyone strange around here?" Jeteo asked. "Someone who counts numbers out loud to himself."

The man nodded.

"...I saw him," the man said. "A good while back. He was walking along counting numbers, over and over. Didn't answer when I spoke to him."

"...Where did he go?" I asked, urgent.

"...I don't know," the man said. "But there's someone who's good at finding people like that. I heard his name is Temel."

The moment I heard that name, something about it felt strangely familiar. I didn't know why, then. Now I do. It was another name that had been quietly finding people, here and there across this world.

. . .

That night, we started walking again in the direction the man had pointed us.

"...This Temel person — do you think it's worth finding him?" I asked.

"...If these footprints belong to Father," Jeteo said, "I'll meet anyone. I'm not letting anything slip past me now."

I set those words down as the last line of this chapter. I knew, that day. Jeteo was no longer someone who only gathered evidence, or raged alone. He was, now, a person who searched. And I was the one who recorded that searching.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. The Man Who Finds People

Previously — The siblings found footprints they didn't recognize. A traveler confirmed that the person had been walking along counting numbers, and told them the name of a man who finds people — Temel.

Two days later, we actually met Temel.

He wasn't a big man. He carried his pack light. His eyes never stopped moving, scanning everything around him.

"...Are you the one who finds people?" Jeteo asked.

Temel stopped walking and looked at us. His eyes flickered, just for a moment.

"...Something like that," Temel said. "Who are you looking for?"

There was something strange in Temel's eyes right then. The look of someone who had done the same thing, over and over, for a very long time. Not tired — a look that had simply grown used to it.

"...We met Speon and Mena," Jeteo said. "They never mentioned you — we came looking for you on our own."

Something shifted, faintly, in Temel's face at those two names.

"...Are the two of them well?" Temel asked. His voice held both gladness and caution.

"...Yes," I said. "Each of them is doing well, where they are."

Temel nodded. He didn't ask anything more. In that silence, I sensed there was some old story among the three of them that we didn't know.

. . .

Jeteo told him about Father — the habit of counting bricks, the footprints, the numbers.

Temel listened and nodded.

"...I've seen people like that a few times," Temel said. "People who've lost their names — mostly they keep repeating something with their hands, or their mouths. Whatever they used to do stays behind in the body."

"...Then can you find him?" Jeteo asked, urgent.

"...I'm a man who finds people," Temel said. "But I'm not a man who carries answers around with him. I'm a man who goes looking."

I didn't understand the difference in that, then. Now I do. Temel wasn't someone who handed you certainty. He was someone who walked alongside you.

"...What if we find him and he's not Father?" I asked. I was afraid to ask it, but it had to be asked.

"...Then we find that person, whoever he is, in his own right," Temel said.

"There's no wasted walking in the finding of someone. Whoever you're looking for, every step of it means something."

That answer comforted me in a strange way. For the first time, I understood that this journey might not be a complete failure even if we never found Father.

. . .

"...Why do you do this?" I asked.

Temel looked off into the distance for a moment.

"...A long time ago, there was a place where I was supposed to guide someone, and I ran," Temel said. "I was afraid, back then. Now I'm still afraid sometimes, but I don't run. That's the only way I have of paying it back."

Hearing that, I thought it sounded like something Speon had once said. I didn't know, then, that the two of them had truly come out of the same story.

. . .

Temel led us walking north for several more days. The whole way, he kept studying the ground — which way the dry grass had been bent down, scratches on stones, even how deep the footprints ran.

"...Found it," Temel said quietly, on the fourth night. Far off, a small light was visible.

The moment I saw that light, I set down the last line of this chapter here. I gripped Jeteo's hand tight again. I couldn't know whether that light was Father. But for the first time, I felt with my whole body that it was possible to walk on without knowing the answer.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Before the Firelight

Previously — The siblings met Temel. Along with his words — "There's no wasted walking in the finding of someone" — on the fourth night they spotted a small light far off in the distance.

We crept carefully toward the light.

It was a small campfire. Someone sat beside it. His back was turned, so we couldn't see his face. But his hand kept moving — the gesture of counting something in the air.

The instant I saw that gesture, I stopped walking. I felt Jeteo stop at the same moment. We stood there gripping each other's hands.

The closer we came, the more we could hear a small sound — made with lips that barely moved.

"...two thousand nine hundred ninety-seven, two thousand nine hundred ninety-eight..."

The moment I heard that number, my legs went weak. I knew exactly where in the count that was. It was almost, almost three thousand. And I understood, for the first time, that since that night, Father had never once managed to reach all the way to three thousand.

. . .

Temel went ahead of us, quietly.

"...Excuse me." Temel spoke low. "Are you all right?"

The man slowly turned his head.

The moment I saw that face, my breath stopped. It hadn't aged, hadn't changed much at all. I was seeing that face for the first time since our last night in Brick Hollow. It was Father.

Jeteo froze right where he stood too. He couldn't say a word. I watched years' worth of feeling pass over his face all at once — anger, relief, fear, and then fear again.

Temel glanced back at us quietly. He seemed about to say something, then simply stepped back — a step that left this moment to us.

. . .

Father looked at us. But there was nothing in his eyes. The eyes of someone looking at strangers.

"...Who are you?" Father asked. His voice was exactly the same. But there was no weight in it toward us at all.

I couldn't say anything at all in that moment. Jeteo stepped forward instead.

"...Do you... know us?" Jeteo asked. His voice had come apart completely.

Father shook his head. His face was apologetic. But there was strangeness even in that apology.

"...I don't know," Father said. "I'm sorry. I don't... even know who I am, myself."

Only then did I reach out and take Father's hand. It was trembling. It held the exact same warmth as the hand that had held mine the night we crossed the

boundary stones, long ago.

"...I'm Elpis," I said. My voice cracked. "I'm Elpis. I'm your daughter."

Father's hand gave the faintest twitch, right then. His eyes still recognized nothing at all. But that hand — that alone was responding to something.

I saw that tremor clearly. I didn't know, then, whether it was memory or just a habit left over in the body. I still don't know exactly, even now. But I decided to hold on to that one tremor.

I set down that answer as the last line of this chapter. I understood, in that moment, for the first time, that finding and losing could happen at once. Father was standing right in front of us. And Father was farther from us than he had ever been.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. How to Sit Beside Someone

Previously — The siblings found Father at last. But he recognized neither their names nor their faces. "I don't even know who I am, myself." When Elpis took his hand, it trembled faintly — a response that could have been memory, or could have been only habit.

That night, Jeteo sat alone a little way off from Father.

I went and sat beside him. I said nothing. He said nothing either.

I knew what he was holding in. He must have imagined this moment for years. But nowhere in that imagining, I think, was there ever a scene where Father didn't know us.

In the distance, Father was still counting something on his fingers. He didn't seem to be sleeping at all.

"...How long is that going to keep going?" Jeteo asked quietly. I couldn't tell if he was asking me, or just himself.

I couldn't answer. I didn't know either.

. . .

Temel sat down quietly beside us.

"...I've seen this kind of thing a few times myself," Temel said. "If you force it, try to drag the memory out, it only frightens him more. Just being there beside him comes first."

"...What good does that do?" Jeteo asked. His voice had an edge to it. "He doesn't even know who we are."

"...What good it does, you might learn later, or you might never," Temel said. "But being there beside him — whether he knows you or not — is the one thing you can actually do, right now."

Hearing that, I thought, strangely, of the Ledger's voice. The Ledger never accepted a case it couldn't "resolve." Temel was telling us to stay beside someone even when we couldn't resolve anything. That day, for the first time, I thought that difference might be the answer to this whole book.

"...Did you have someone who stayed beside you like this?" I asked.

Temel was silent for a long time, then gave a small nod.

"...I did," Temel said. "If it hadn't been for him, I'd still be running, even now."

. . .

The next morning, Jeteo went up to Father.

"...Would you like to come with us?" Jeteo asked carefully. "If you don't know where else to go."

Father looked at Jeteo for a long moment. His eyes were still the eyes of someone looking at a stranger. But there was, just barely, something in them that wasn't wariness.

"...Why are you helping me?" Father asked.

Jeteo was at a loss for a moment. I knew he wanted to say, "Because you're my father." But he chose different words.

"...No reason," Jeteo said. "It's all right to help someone without a reason."

I was startled to hear that answer. In Haven, Jeteo had been someone who believed there was no such thing as helping without a reason. I felt, right then, that he was becoming, little by little, a different person.

. . .

In the end, Father nodded.

"...Then... I'll take you up on that," Father said.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. Hearing them, I nearly laughed, in a strange way. Father had just told us he'd "take us up on it." For the first time, I understood that becoming someone who walked with us could come before becoming someone who knew us again.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. While He Had No Name

Previously — The siblings began learning how to stay beside Father instead of forcing his memory to return. Father, to these strangers, said, "I'll take you up on that," and agreed to walk with them.

From that day, the four of us walked together.

Father still counted on his fingers sometimes. But not as constantly as before. I didn't know whether that was a good sign or not.

Every time I saw that gesture, something in me twisted. I wanted it to stop. But at the same time, I was afraid of it stopping too — afraid it might be the only proof left that Father had ever been Father.

Every time Jeteo saw it, he quietly took Father's hand. At first, Father was startled. After a few days, he stopped pulling his hand away.

"...It's strange, holding this hand makes me feel a little at ease," Father said. "I don't know why."

Hearing that, I looked at Jeteo's face. He said nothing. But I saw that his eyes were wet.

. . .

"...What should we call you?" Jeteo asked carefully, that first evening.

Father looked flustered by the question.

"...I'm not sure myself," Father said. "I don't think I... have a name."

For a moment, none of us could speak. Then I was the first to say something.

"...Then can we choose one for you? If you remember your real name later, we can change it then."

Father smiled a little at that. It felt like the first smile I'd seen in a long time.

"...I'd like that," Father said.

. . .

That night we thought over names. Jeteo couldn't settle on any. I felt like I already knew.

"...How about 'Waiting'?" I said. "Someone I know has a name that means something like that."

Father said the name aloud a few times, trying it out.

"...Waiting," Father said. "That's not bad. I really do feel like I'm waiting for something, right now."

"...Waiting for what?" Jeteo asked.

Father thought for a moment, then said,

"...I don't know. But the feeling that I'm waiting for something — that much is certain."

I nearly cried, hearing that answer. I understood, then. Father had forgotten his name, forgotten faces, but he hadn't forgotten the shape of that feeling —

waiting. I couldn't be certain it was a waiting for us. But I decided to believe it was.

. . .

Temel walked with us a few more days, then stopped at a fork in the road.

"...I need to take a different road from here," Temel said. "There's someone else I need to go find."

"...Thank you," Jeteo said. His voice was sincere.

Temel looked at us and said one last thing.

"...Until your father finds his real name again, you two hold his place. A person can lose his name and still not lose the place where he's loved."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. We parted from Temel that day and went on walking, the three of us again. For the first time, I felt this journey's purpose changing — from finding an answer, to holding a place.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. The Man Who Came in the Night

Previously — The siblings gave the nameless Father a temporary name — Waiting. Parting from Temel, they heard him say, "A person can lose his name and still not lose the place where he's loved."

That night, Father woke suddenly, shouting.

"...Where is this! Why am I here!" Father shouted. His eyes were wide open. Even looking straight at us, they didn't recognize us at all.

When Jeteo tried to move closer, Father backed away.

I was so frightened in that moment that my body froze. It wasn't Father attacking us that scared me most — it was that look in his eyes, seeing us as complete strangers.

"...It's all right, it's all right," Jeteo said, raising both hands, keeping his voice as low as he could. "We won't hurt you."

Even so, Father couldn't calm down. He kept gasping for breath, looking around wildly. Watching him, unable to do anything, frightened me all the more.

. . .

That's when someone came quietly out of the dark.

"...It's all right," said a familiar voice. "Breathe slowly."

I recognized the voice. It was the man from the flowerbed. No — he was just the man now. The one who'd been there in a place no one had planted, the one they said had been seen at the well too.

"...Why are you here..." Jeteo couldn't finish, too startled.

He didn't answer. He simply sat down quietly in front of Father.

. . .

"...Who am I?" Father asked him — a question he hadn't asked us.

"...You don't have to know, right now," he said. "Even without a name, you're here, right now. That's enough."

Father's breathing slowly settled.

"...Aren't you afraid of me?" Father asked.

"...I'm not afraid," he said. "I've met a great many people who've lost their names."

Hearing that, I looked at Jeteo. His face held a complicated look — suspicion, and something that couldn't overcome that suspicion, both at once.

He kept speaking to Father in a low voice. I couldn't hear all of it. But the way he spoke was strangely like the way Mother used to speak, putting us to bed back in Brick Hollow.

I couldn't explain that resemblance, then. I still can't explain it exactly, even now. But since that night, I've known that a stranger's voice can carry a kind of familiarity too.

. . .

After Father had fallen back asleep, Jeteo went up to the man.

"...Who are you, really?" Jeteo asked. His voice had an edge. "Brick Hollow, Haven, now all the way out here... why do you keep showing up?"

He looked at Jeteo for a long moment.

"...I've always been here," he said. "You're the ones who didn't recognize me."

"...What does that mean?"

He smiled quietly. He didn't answer.

I set down that non-answer as the last line of this chapter. That night, I saw something on Jeteo's face deeper than anger. I thought it was fear. Now I know. It was his certainty, beginning, ever so slowly, to crack.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Humming

Previously — When Father woke in the night in violent confusion, the man from the flowerbed appeared again and calmed him. Jeteo asked him outright who he was, but the only answer that came back was, "I've always been here. You're the ones who didn't recognize me."

By the next morning, the man had vanished without a word.

"...He just left again," Jeteo said, his voice empty. "Every single time. He shows up, and then — no explanation at all."

I had nothing to say against that. But strangely, his disappearing felt different to me from being abandoned. I couldn't explain exactly why, then.

Father didn't even remember the man had been there. That saddened me. The very voice that had calmed us all so completely last night — Father himself didn't have even a trace of it left.

I thought, then — maybe there are things that stay even when they can't be remembered. Like that song.

. . .

That afternoon, Father hummed something low as he walked.

The moment I heard it, I stopped walking. I knew that tune. It was the one Mother used to sing to put us to sleep.

"...Father, what song is that?" I asked, urgent.

Father stopped humming and looked at me. His face was flustered.

"...I don't know," Father said. "It just... came out on its own."

My heart felt like it would burst. I looked at Jeteo. His face showed that he'd recognized the tune too.

. . .

"...Can you keep singing it?" Jeteo asked. His voice shook.

Father tried to hum it again. But he got stuck after only a few bars.

"...I can't remember what comes next," Father said, his face apologetic.

"...It's all right," I said. I was crying. "That's enough."

I picked up where it left off and sang the rest myself, exactly the way Mother used to. Father closed his eyes, listening.

"...It's strange, it settles something in me," Father said. "Even though I don't know whose song it was."

In that moment I understood again why I was still keeping this record. This song, this moment — these were things to give back to Father, someday, whenever he returned whole.

That night I tried to write the tune down on paper. But I didn't know how to write down a melody in words. In the end I just wrote this: "Today, Father hummed Mother's song. He couldn't sing it to the end. But he sang it."

. . .

That night, Jeteo said to me quietly,

"...I still don't really know. Who that man is. Whether I'm supposed to believe in God."

"...But?" I asked.

"...But listening to that humming today, just for a moment, I thought this: maybe, the way something still remains inside Father, something remains inside me too. Something not completely erased."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I understood how enormous it was that Jeteo had said that out loud, for the first time — to himself, and to me.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The Light Returns

Previously — Father hummed Mother's lullaby without even realizing it — the first fragment of memory left in his body. For the first time, Jeteo said aloud, of himself, "Maybe something inside me hasn't been completely erased either."

A few nights later, that low light appeared in the sky again.

"...The searching light," Jeteo said, low. A familiar fear had returned to his voice.

The moment I saw the light, I checked on Father first. He was just looking up at the sky, not knowing at all what it was.

"...It's pretty," Father said, innocently. Something about that ached strangely in my chest. Father had no idea at all what that light meant.

"...Father, hurry," Jeteo said, pulling urgently at his arm. "Explanations later."

. . .

"...We have to hide," Jeteo said. We ducked quickly behind a low rock. Father crouched down with us too. He couldn't have known the exact reason. But he followed along without question.

The light drew closer and closer. I held my breath.

A strange thought struck me right then. Whether that light was searching for us, or for Father. Father was already someone marked COMPLETE. Did they come

searching again, even for someone already complete?

. . .

The light paused for a moment right above our heads.

That moment felt like forever. Jeteo gripped my hand tight. Father took my other hand too. He didn't know why, but he seemed to sense something dangerous.

The light moved again. This time, not toward us — it went off in another direction.

I couldn't breathe properly until the light was completely gone. What came before relief was a strange guilt — the thought that the light might be searching for someone else right now instead.

"...Are you all right?" Jeteo asked me. Only then did I realize I was shaking.

"...Yeah," I said. It was a lie. Jeteo's face showed he knew it was a lie too. But he just squeezed my hand once more.

. . .

After the light was gone, Jeteo said, low,

"...We really do need to get far away from Haven now. Even out here is inside that eye's reach, it seems."

"...Go where?" I asked.

"...Anywhere," Father put in carefully. "As long as I'm not a burden."

Jeteo thought for a moment, then said,

"...I don't know. But we have to keep walking. You, us — staying here is dangerous for all of us."

Hearing that, Father asked quietly,

"...Am I a burden?"

Jeteo looked at him, startled by the question.

"...No," Jeteo said firmly. "You're not a burden. We're going together."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I saw that Jeteo looked startled by his own words, even as he said them. It seemed like he was saying them to himself, at the same time as he said them to Father.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. A Night on the Run

Previously — The searching light appeared again. It passed them by, thankfully, but guilt lingered behind that relief. When Father asked, "Am I a burden?" Jeteo answered, "We're going together."

Two nights later, this time it wasn't a light that came, but people.

Footsteps. Several of them. We hurried to hide ourselves behind dry brush.

I gripped Father's hand as hard as I could. I wanted him to understand that we had to stay quiet. But the unfamiliar sound frightened him instead, and he began to shake.

Voices came to us. Low, businesslike.

"...They said there was a reading around here?"

"...Two candidates for Reassignment review. And there's a report that one COMPLETE record has strayed."

My body froze the moment I heard that. I knew "one COMPLETE record has strayed" meant Father. For the first time, I felt in my whole body that even Father, to this city, was not a person but an entry.

. . .

"...Shh." Jeteo carefully covered Father's mouth with his hand, as gently as he could. "You have to be quiet. Please."

Father nodded, eyes wide. He didn't know why, but he seemed to sense the danger.

The footsteps came closer and closer. Three people in Haven uniforms passed by. Each carried some bright instrument in hand.

I didn't know what the instrument was. But I knew it was meant to find us.

Jeteo gave me a slight push, tucking me behind him. Even in that moment, it was a gesture that put me first. I was used to that gesture, but that day it ached in a way I hadn't felt before.

I knew he was afraid too. But he was trying to carry all of that fear by himself. The way he always had.

. . .

One of them stopped right in front of the brush where we hid.

I thought my breath would stop. Jeteo pulled Father closer, holding him tighter.

The person shone the instrument toward the brush. Light swept past right beside us.

I squeezed my eyes shut in that moment. For the first time in my life, I prayed something — not in words, just in my heart. I didn't even know whether it was a prayer. I just prayed.

The person soon turned and walked off in another direction.

. . .

Even after the footsteps had completely faded, we couldn't move from that spot for a long while.

At last Jeteo let out a breath and looked up at the sky.

"...Where are you," Jeteo said, low but clear. I knew who he was speaking to. "You don't show up for this, but you showed up back then?"

There was no answer. The night sky was just the night sky.

I set down that silence as the last line of this chapter. I understood how fair Jeteo's question was. I couldn't give him an answer. No one could. But even inside that silence, I held on to one single fact — that we were still alive.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Wrong Direction

Previously — A Haven search party actually came after the siblings. After the danger passed, Jeteo asked the night sky, "You don't show up for this, but you showed up back then?" — but only silence answered.

The next day, we started walking again, as quietly as we could.

Jeteo barely spoke all that day. I didn't want to disturb him, so I just walked beside him.

I understood that his silence was connected to last night's question. I learned, that day, that a question with no answer stays on as silence, in place of an answer.

Father, of all days, was unusually bright. I didn't know why. He just said he liked walking. I envied that brightness. Since Father remembered nothing, by morning even last night's terror seemed almost entirely forgotten.

For the first time, I thought forgetting might not only be a curse. It was a strange thought. I didn't hold on to it for long.

. . .

In the afternoon, we met a merchant coming from the opposite direction. He spoke to us first.

"...This area was in an uproar last night," the merchant said. "I heard the search party was chasing someone and ended up completely off track."

"...Off track?" Jeteo asked, ears pricking up.

"...Yeah. Some old man supposedly pointed them the wrong way. And when they went to look for him afterward, he'd disappeared too, they say. It's going around as a strange story among their people."

The moment I heard that, I looked at Jeteo. He looked at me too. Neither of us said anything, but I knew we were thinking the same thing.

"...What did the old man look like?" Jeteo asked, unable to hold back.

The merchant shrugged.

"...I only heard it secondhand, so I don't know. Just that he was wearing worn-out clothes, that's all I heard."

That answer alone was enough. I could see in Jeteo's face that he thought so too.

. . .

After the merchant left, Jeteo was quiet for a long time before he spoke.

"...Was it him?"

"...I don't know," I said. But in my heart, I was already almost certain.

"...Then why doesn't he just say so from the start?" Jeteo asked, his voice mixed with frustration. "Then I wouldn't have to keep getting angry like this, every time."

I didn't know the answer to that. But a strange thought came to me, then. Maybe telling us ahead of time would be worth less than walking through the fear together.

. . .

Father had been listening quietly to the conversation, and asked,

"...Who is he?"

Jeteo couldn't answer right away. After a long while, he said,

"...I don't really know either. But... it seems like he's always around us somehow. Without ever explaining."

Father gave a small laugh at that.

"...Then he's a bit like me," Father said. "I can't explain who I am either, and yet here I am."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. In that moment I saw an expression on Jeteo's face I'd never seen before. It wasn't anger. It wasn't certainty either. It was simply the face of someone who had opened his heart, just a little.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. He Called My Name

Previously — From the merchant they heard about an old man who had led the Haven search party the wrong way. Without a word, the siblings were both certain who it was. At Father's offhand remark, an expression appeared on Jeteo's face for the first time that was neither anger nor certainty.

A few days later, we were resting by a small stream.

Father was washing his hands in the water when he suddenly called out to me.

"...Elpis."

My whole body froze in that instant. Jeteo's did too.

We had told Father my name many times over these days. But that had only ever been introducing myself. This was different. Father had called me. The difference might not have looked like much, but to me it was as large as the whole world.

. . .

Father looked startled at his own words, as if they'd surprised him too.

"...What... did I just say?" Father asked.

"...My name," I managed to say. My voice shook. "You called my name."

Father touched his own mouth with his hand, as if trying to check where the word had come from.

"...How did I know that," Father murmured. "It just... came out on its own."

I looked at Jeteo in that moment. He stood there, unable to say a word. I saw tears well up in his eyes for the first time.

I went to Father and took his hand.

"...Say it again," I said.

"...Elpis." Father said it again. This time with certainty. Tears filled his eyes. "Elpis, Elpis..."

That name reached past being just my name — it sounded like something Father was saying to himself. As if he were gripping that one name and struggling to find his way back to himself.

. . .

"...What about me?" Jeteo asked, his voice trembling. "Do you know my name too?"

Father looked at him for a long time. His face was that of someone reaching for something just out of grasp.

"...I'm sorry," Father said. "That one... hasn't come yet."

Jeteo's face fell. I watched his disappointment plainly. But strangely, he smiled.

"...It's all right," Jeteo said. "My name can come later. Right now... it's enough that Elpis's name came out."

I was startled to hear that. For the first time, I saw Jeteo accept someone else's joy before his own.

. . .

That night, Jeteo said to me quietly,

"...I've been gathering evidence this whole time. To protect the name, to remember. But today I understood. What's coming back inside Father — it wasn't because I gathered evidence. It was just... because we were beside him."

"...So evidence doesn't matter anymore?" I asked.

"...No," Jeteo said. "It still matters. But now I know. Evidence alone wouldn't have been enough. Being beside him had to be there too."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. That night, I watched Jeteo hold two things together for the first time — keeping, and staying beside. I didn't know exactly, then, that this was his first step toward trust.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. A Place to Plant

Previously — Father, for the first time, spoke Elpis's name of his own accord. Jeteo realized it hadn't come back because they gathered evidence, but because they had stayed beside him — and began holding keeping and staying beside together.

"...Where should we go now?" Jeteo asked one evening. It was a question for Father as much as for me.

There were limits to walking on like this, always as if fleeing. Father still tired easily, and still couldn't rest fully at ease, even by night.

I felt, then, that what we needed was no longer an answer, but a place. Not a direction to walk toward, but somewhere to put down roots.

I read back over the record I'd been keeping. From our last night in Brick Hollow up to now, page after page was filled. I felt anew how few answers were in that record. But it held more than answers. It held the days we had walked together.

. . .

"...What if we went back to Speon's?" I said. "That well wasn't dangerous. And Speon... he was alone too."

Jeteo turned the thought over.

"...That doesn't sound bad," Jeteo said. "We need help, and Speon needs help too."

Father asked quietly,

"...If we go there... would it be all right for me to be there too?"

Jeteo looked straight at Father.

"...Of course," Jeteo said. This time there was no hesitation at all.

. . .

We started walking south again, toward Speon's well.

The way back felt shorter than the way we'd first set out. It wasn't only that we knew the road.

Speon looked startled to see us. And more startled still, seeing Father.

"...You found him," Speon said. There was real gladness in his voice.

"...Yes," Jeteo said. "But not completely found. We're still finding him."

I copy down Jeteo's words here exactly. He had learned, now, to tell "found" apart from "still finding."

Speon drew Father a bowl of water. Father drank it, looking around at the well.

"...It's strange, this place feels at ease," Father said.

"...That makes sense," Speon said quietly. "This is just the kind of place it is."

. . .

That evening, I planted a few seeds in a small patch of ground beside the well. The leaf I'd brought from that flowerbed in Haven had dried up long ago. But I still remembered the hands that had given me the seed, right there.

Father sat beside me and watched.

"...What are you planting?" Father asked.

"...I don't know yet," I said. "But if I plant it, I suppose I'll find out eventually."

Father smiled quietly at that.

"...I think I'm a bit like that too," Father said. "I don't know yet what's inside me. But I know something's been planted."

I set down those words as the last line of this Part. That evening we made our place at Speon's well. The answers still hadn't all come. Neither had the name, nor Jeteo's certainty — not yet, not all the way. But that day, for the first time, I knew we had found somewhere to put down roots.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Four

By the Well

Chapter 37. Days by the Well

Previously — Sensing they needed a place to stand rather than an answer to hold, the two of them went back to Speon's well and settled there. Elpis planted the seed again, and Father said, "I know it's planted."

That was how we began to live by the well.

The days weren't very different from one another. In the morning we drew water, walked with Father, and in the evening I set down the record. At first the sameness felt strange to me. Haven, and the road we'd run on before that — those had always been time spent being chased by something.

That was the first time I understood how precious an ordinary day could be. How rare a gift a day with nothing happening in it was — I hadn't known that, in Brick Hollow.

Father got a little better, bit by bit. He still didn't know Brother's name. But during the day he started trying to do things himself, for short stretches. Drawing water. Moving stones. Without anyone telling him to.

"...It's easier when I'm doing something," Father said. "When my body's moving."

Hearing that, I thought of Father in Brick Hollow. Those hands had always been moving too. I felt, then, that something inside Father was coming back before his name was.

. . .

Brother started helping Speon tend the well. He repaired the bucket, repaired the stone wall, and at night took turns keeping watch with Speon.

"...Why are you helping with this?" I asked.

"...Speon did this alone for a long time," Brother said. "I think I get it now. Why waiting can become a job."

Hearing that, I knew Brother had started to understand Speon's life. It wasn't an understanding he'd gotten from an answer. It was an understanding he'd gotten from doing the work alongside him.

Speon, while teaching Brother how to repair the bucket, would sometimes let slip a little of his own past. How once, out of fear, he'd run and left someone behind. Brother didn't press him about it. He just listened.

"...Why don't you ask more?" Speon asked.

"...I've learned lately that it's better to talk about something when you want to," Brother said.

. . .

One night, there was a sound at the well.

The four of us ran to it at the same time. A woman had just come up out of the bottom of the well and was shaking. Her eyes had nothing in them.

Brother was the first to go to her.

"...It's all right." Brother said it in the same voice we'd once heard from Father. "Breathe slowly. You're safe here."

Watching that, my breath caught. Brother was standing, now, most calmly of all of us, in the exact place he'd been most afraid of only months before.

. . .

The woman stayed by the well for a few days, and then remembered part of her name. Not all of it. But even with just that much, she wept and laughed.

That night, Brother said to me,

"...I still don't know who that man is. I can't even say I believe in God. But watching that woman today, I knew something. I know how to be beside someone now. That much is certain."

I set that down as the last sentence of this chapter. I knew Brother still couldn't use the word faith. But he was already doing what faith does. I decided not to think that order was strange.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Mena Came

Previously — Living by the well had begun. Brother helped Speon tend the well and learned how to be beside someone. "I can't say I believe in God. But I know how to be beside someone."

About a month later, on a certain day, a familiar figure walked toward us from far off.

It was Mena. She had her record box, the one she always carried, slung over her shoulder.

The moment I saw her, I ran to her. Mena remembered us. And then she saw Father and stopped walking.

"...Did you come to bring news to Speon?" I asked.

"...That too," Mena said. Her face colored a little. "I wanted to know how you two were doing, as well."

. . .

"...Is this—" Mena couldn't finish the sentence.

"...Yes." Brother said. "We found him. His name hasn't all come back yet, though."

Mena's eyes filled with tears. It was the first time I'd seen her show feeling like that.

"...Of all the names I've recorded, meeting one again like this is really rare," Mena said. "Thank you. For not giving up."

"...It's thanks to you, Ma'am," Brother said. "If you hadn't recorded his name, we'd have just kept walking for nothing."

Mena shook her head.

"...I only wrote it down," Mena said. "You were the ones who walked and found him."

. . .

Speon heard the news and came running out from the well. The moment he saw Mena, he stopped walking.

The two of them said nothing for a while.

"...You said you were still waiting," Mena said first.

"...I did," Speon said. "That still holds."

I felt, in that short exchange, how much time had passed between them. I still didn't know what had happened between the two of them. But that day, I decided for the first time not to ask. I'd learned that some stories deserve to be respected without explanation.

Mena stayed by the well for several days after that. I caught myself watching, more than once, the sight of her and Speon sitting side by side filling water jars. They didn't say much to each other. But that silence was nothing like any silence I'd seen before.

. . .

That night, Mena took a piece of paper out of her record box and showed it to Father.

"...This is your name," Mena said. "Exactly as your children told it to me. I wrote it down and carried it with me."

Father looked at the paper for a long time. Even reading his own name, his face wasn't sure it belonged to him.

"...Is this... my name?" Father asked.

"...Yes," Mena said. "It's the name your children never once forgot."

I set that down as the last sentence of this chapter. I heard Father read his own name aloud in that moment. It still came out sounding unfamiliar. But inside that unfamiliarity, I felt something coming back, very slowly.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. I've Been There

Previously — Mena came to the well and met Father. When she showed him the name she'd written down for him, Father read his own name aloud for the first time. It still felt unfamiliar, but something was slowly coming back.

After Mena left again, another person came up out of the well.

This time it was a boy, young — about ten, it looked like. As soon as he came up, he couldn't even cry. He just sat there, blank.

Watching him, I remembered the months before, when we first met Father. I remember how helpless we'd been then.

Speon did what he always did and brought water first. The boy took the water but couldn't drink it. His hands were shaking.

I saw that shaking. And for the first time I understood that this place held too many people for Speon to carry alone. Now we were with him too.

. . .

Brother sat down quietly beside the boy.

"...I've been there too," Brother said. "Our father came up out of here just like this. At first he didn't know anything either."

The boy looked at Brother. For the first time there was something in his eyes.

"...And now?" the boy asked. His voice cracked.

"...Now he can read his own name out loud," Brother said. "Not all of it. But it's coming back, bit by bit."

. . .

From that day the boy followed Brother everywhere. He tried to copy everything Brother did.

"...Why are you helping me?" the boy asked one day.

Brother thought for a moment before answering.

"...Because I've had it done for me," Brother said. "Someone being there beside me — I've had that too. So I can do it too."

Hearing that answer, I understood one whole sentence for the first time. Someone who has never been loved finds it harder to learn how to love. Brother was passing on, exactly as it was, what he had received.

After a few days the boy started smiling a little. He still didn't know his own name. But he liked the temporary name Brother had given him.

"...Can I find my real name too, someday?" the boy asked.

"...Yes," Brother said. "Slowly. But it'll come back for sure."

. . .

That night, Brother said to me,

"...I felt something strange today, talking to that boy."

"...What was it?"

"...I was saying, word for word, what that man taught me. 'Even without a name, you're here now. That's enough.' I never memorized that line. It just came out."

I set that down as the last sentence of this chapter. I knew then. Brother still couldn't explain who that man was. But he was already carrying the man's words in his body. That day, for the first time, I was certain how close that was to the beginning of faith.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Going to Him First

Previously — A new child who had lost his name came up out of the well. Brother passed on to him, exactly as it was, what he knew about being beside someone. And he realized, on his own, that he was carrying in his body the words he'd learned from the man at the flowerbed, without ever having memorized them.

The man appeared and vanished with no set time.

Some days he touched the soil by the well. Some days he sat quietly beside someone newly come up. No one ever knew when he would come.

It was around then that I began to notice that irregularity was, in fact, the rule. He was always there at the moment he was most needed.

Neither Speon nor Mena ever asked him certain things when they were with him. When he'd come, why now. Living by the well, I came to understand that their silence wasn't resignation. It was an ease that only someone who had watched him a long time could have.

. . .

One afternoon, he was sitting alone in the shade of the tree by the well.

Brother walked over to him. I didn't follow. I knew that was Brother's place to go alone.

"...Can I talk to you?" Brother asked. It wasn't the accusing tone from before.

I watched from a distance. For the first time, I saw Brother going to find him. It had always been the man who appeared first. This time Brother went to him first.

Watching his back, I thought of the last night in Brick Hollow. The night Brother had shouted up at the sky. Back then he'd gone toward him in anger. Now he was walking toward him. I knew that difference was a large one.

. . .

The man motioned with his hand to the seat beside him. Brother sat down.

For a long while, neither of them spoke. Even from a distance, I could feel that the silence wasn't from awkwardness.

"...I still don't really know," Brother said at last. "Who you are. Why you keep showing up. Whether I'm supposed to believe in God."

"...I know," he said.

"...But there's one thing I do know," Brother said. "I know how to be beside someone now. But when I think about where I learned it... in the end, it's from you."

. . .

At that, he turned and looked at Brother straight on for the first time.

"...Then let me ask you one thing," he said. "Why do you still not trust me?"

Brother was silent for a long time.

"...Because I'm afraid," Brother said finally. "If I believe, and it ends up like it did with Father again... I don't think I could bear it this time. Not really."

I set down that answer as the last sentence of this chapter. I heard Brother, for the first time, say out loud the real reason for his doubt. It wasn't logic. It was fear. I knew, in that moment, that Brother had come a very little bit closer.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. I've Lost Someone Too

Previously — For the first time, Brother went to find the man at the flowerbed on his own. Asked "Why do you still not trust me?", Brother said, for the first time, the real reason: "If I believe, and it ends up like it did with Father again... I don't think I could bear it this time. Not really."

He was silent for a long time after hearing Brother's words.

I watched that silence from a distance. I knew it wasn't a dismissive silence. It was a silence that was weighing something.

The wind shook the tree by the well. Brother stayed right there through that silence. He didn't run. That alone told me how far Brother had come.

"...I know that feeling," he said at last.

"...How would you know that?" Brother asked. There was still an edge in it.

. . .

"...Because I've lost someone too," he said.

Brother's face showed surprise at that.

"...What did you lose?"

He looked off into the distance for a moment.

"...It would take a long time to explain," he said. "But I can tell you one thing. I'm not going to promise you I won't lose you again. That's a promise I couldn't keep. But I can promise you one thing instead. When it happens, I won't leave you alone."

The moment I heard that, tears came to me, strangely. I didn't understand it then. Why he didn't say it wouldn't hurt. I understand it now. He wasn't someone who gave false comfort.

"...Aren't you going to tell me who you lost?" Brother asked.

"...Someday," he said. "Not now. Right now is your story's time, not mine."

Strangely, that answer settled well with me. It was the first time I felt that he wasn't trying to cover our grief with his own.

. . .

"...Then why did our father end up like that?" Brother asked. His voice shook. "Why didn't you stop it?"

"...I can't give you that answer either," he said. "If I could give it to you, I already would have."

"...Then what can you give me?"

"...This, right now," he said. And he held out his hand. "Sitting beside you."

Brother looked at that hand for a long time. From a distance, I saw his shoulders shaking.

Brother took the hand.

I set down that answer as the last sentence of this chapter. I knew, then, that the answer this whole book had been searching for had never existed as a sentence to begin with. That answer was shaped like the hand he held out. And Brother, that day, answered by taking it.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. The Three of Us, Sitting

Previously — To Brother's confession of fear, the man answered not with an argument but with the fact that he too had lost someone. "When it happens, I won't leave you alone." And he held out his hand. Brother took it.

That evening, for the first time, I sat with Brother under that same shade tree.

He was already gone. Vanished quietly, as he always did. But something like warmth from where he had been still remained in that spot.

I didn't know what to call that warmth. I still can't find the exact word for it now. I just set it down as it was.

Brother sat under that tree for a long while. I asked nothing, sitting beside him. I had learned, by then, that some moments suit silence better than questions.

. . .

"...Do you believe now?" I asked.

Brother couldn't answer right away.

"...I don't know," Brother said. "But when I took that hand a little while ago... something changed. I can't explain exactly what."

"...Is the anger gone?"

"...No," Brother said. "The anger's still there. What happened to Father still makes me angry. But now I know I don't have to hold that anger alone."

I thought that answer was strangely honest. Brother didn't say, "It's all fine now." I thought that honesty was so like him.

"...Elpis, when did you start believing?" Brother asked.

I thought about that question for a long time.

"...I don't know," I said. "At some point, I just started waiting. Before I even had the words to say I believed."

. . .

Father walked over to us then. He had a few small stones in his hand.

"...What were you two doing?" Father asked.

"...Just sitting," Brother said.

Father sat down beside us naturally. That day was the first time the three of us sat side by side.

I record that moment exactly. Father didn't know what we'd been talking about. But in that moment, something felt complete, just from the three of us sitting there together.

. . .

"...Why are you collecting these stones?" I asked.

Father set each stone on his palm and looked at it, one by one.

"...I don't know," Father said. "I just thought they looked nice. And... I feel like I want to give them to someone. I don't know who."

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I nearly cried in that moment. Father didn't know. But Father's body knew. Gathering something for someone — that had always been the thing Father did.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. What Mother Never Got to Say

Previously — After taking the hand, Brother answered honestly: "The anger's still there. But now I know I don't have to hold that anger alone." Not knowing why, Father had been gathering stones because he wanted to give them to someone.

A few nights later, Father suddenly bolted upright out of sleep.

"...Jeteo." Father said it with his eyes open.

Brother startled at the sound and sat up.

"...Me?" Brother asked. His voice shook.

I held my breath in that moment. Father had called Brother's name for the first time. But Father's face was still the confused face of someone not fully out of sleep.

"...It's all right, Father." I said it, and the word "Father" came out of me naturally, without my meaning it to. Father, too, paused for a moment at the word. But his wasn't a face that disliked it.

. . .

"...Your mother..." Father said, stumbling over it. "Not long before they took me away, one night, she said something like this to me. That there was something she wanted to say to you, but she still couldn't."

Brother froze where he sat.

"...Do you remember what it was?" Brother asked. His voice cracked all the way through.

Father closed his eyes and strained a long while. I watched him strain, and clenched my hands tight.

. . .

"...'You're a child who's always going to be asking,'" Father said finally. Slowly, one word at a time. "'And that's not a bad thing. I'm... proud of that.' That's what I think she was trying to say."

Brother sank down where he stood when he heard it.

I record that moment exactly. It was the first time I'd seen Brother cry like that. Out loud, hard. For the first time since we'd left Brick Hollow.

Hearing those words, I thought of the night we crossed the boundary stones. The night Mother called Brother's name, opened her mouth, and closed it again. "... No. Never mind. Go and live. That's enough." I understood, then, for the first time, that what Mother had tried and failed to say that night had already been left, ahead of time, with Father.

. . .

"...Was Mother never ashamed," Brother asked, "of how much I kept asking?" He asked it of Father, or maybe of nothing at all.

Father put a hand on Brother's shoulder. The gesture was still clumsy. But there was something certain in it.

"...She said she was proud," Father said again. "That much, I remember exactly."

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, I watched Brother receive the answer to a question he'd been asking himself for years — was it wrong of me to keep asking? — the latest it could possibly come, from the person he'd least expect to bring it.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. The Meaning of Our Names

Previously — Father called Brother's name for the first time. And he remembered that, the night before he was taken, Mother had left with him, ahead of time, the words she'd wanted to say to Brother. "You're a child who's always going to be asking. I'm proud of that." That night, for the first time, Brother cried out loud.

A few days later, Father called us over with a somewhat clearer look on his face.

"...I remember who named you two," Father said.

I stopped what I was doing at that.

Brother did too. From Brick Hollow to now, we had never once asked what our names meant. A name was just a name. Something you were called by — that was all.

. . .

"...Your mother named you," Father said. "There was an old language, back where she was from. A language that puts meaning into names. She named you two with that language."

"...What does it mean?" Brother asked.

Father searched hard in his memory for a moment.

"...Jeteo means... 'to seek,' 'to search,'" Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child is going to spend his whole life asking things, digging for the bottom of

them. That's going to be his name."

The moment I heard that, my breath caught. I looked at Brother. Brother stood there, unable to say anything. That name lined up exactly with every way Brother had lived, from Brick Hollow to now.

"...So I just... lived out my name?" Brother asked. Bewilderment was mixed into his voice.

"...Or maybe the name followed you," I said. "Either way — isn't it strange?"

. . .

"...And Elpis?" I asked. My voice shook.

"...Hope," Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child is going to keep waiting, for no reason at all. That's going to be her name.'"

The moment I heard that, tears poured out of me. I thought of the seed, the flowerbed, the heart that had watered it every day and waited. My whole life I hadn't known why I was someone who waited so well. Now I know. It was my name.

. . .

"...Did Mother know we'd turn out like this?" Brother asked.

Father shook his head.

"...I don't think she knew," Father said. "But I think she knew what kind of people you two would become. Someone who searches. Someone who waits."

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, for the first time that day, that we hadn't lived according to the meaning of our names. We had simply lived as ourselves, and that life had been inside our names from the very beginning. It took me a long time, thinking it over, to see how large that difference was.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. News Temel Brought

Previously — Father revealed the meaning of our names. Jeteo means "to seek, to search"; Elpis means "hope." It came out that every way the two of us had lived had already been inside our names.

Around the start of autumn, Temel stopped by the well again.

"...It's been a while," Brother greeted him warmly. His face was far more at ease than it had been months before.

Temel saw Father and smiled.

"...You look much better," Temel said.

Father looked at Temel with something like curiosity.

"...You're the one who first came looking for me, aren't you?" Father asked. It wasn't an exact memory. But something seemed to have stayed with him.

"...That's right," Temel said, his face showing surprise.

. . .

That evening, Temel gave us what news there was.

"...You want to hear about Haven?" Temel asked.

Brother nodded. There was none of the old anger in it. Just curiosity.

"...Still quiet," Temel said. "But I've heard that quiet's gotten some cracks in it lately. More and more people refusing COMPLETE, not filing at all."

Hearing that, something in me stirred strangely. We hadn't gone there to change that city. But it seemed like something had been left behind, in the place we walked away from.

"...Aren't those people in danger?" I asked.

"...They are," Temel said plainly. "But they don't stop, apparently. Once someone starts first, it seems to get a little easier for the next one."

. . .

"...What about the Administrator?" I asked.

"...Still there," Temel said. "But not long ago, there was a rumor — that someone secretly made a room where they keep remembering the names of the people marked COMPLETE. They say the Administrator knows about the room and looks the other way."

In that moment, I thought of the Administrator's face. The face that used to say, "That isn't mine to answer." I thought that maybe he was still resisting, inside that city, in his own way.

. . .

"...And Noa?" Brother asked.

"...Doing well. Her tent camp has gotten bigger, they say. More and more people are showing up who remember names."

Brother smiled quietly at that.

"...It's strange," Brother said. "We just ran. But something's growing in every place we ran through."

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, then. A seed grows even without the one who planted it seeing all of it. We were learning that fact in our bodies.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. A Moment Like a Father

Previously — Temel brought word from outside. Haven is still quiet, but more people are refusing COMPLETE. "We just ran, but something's growing in every place we ran through."

As winter drew near, a cold wind began to blow through by the well.

I'd been getting by on one thin coat. One morning, Father took off his own coat and wrapped it around my shoulders.

"...You looked cold," Father said. As if it were nothing at all.

Speon, watching from the side, smiled quietly. I felt like I understood why. Speon must have seen countless small gestures like that, here by the well.

. . .

I couldn't say anything in that moment. It was such a small gesture. But inside that gesture was something that had come before name or memory.

I understood then. Being a father isn't about remembering — it's about noticing the cold first. Father didn't know that about himself. But he was already doing it.

"...Are you cold?" I asked.

"...I'm fine," Father said, smiling — while looking cold himself. Strangely, I was grateful for that lie.

. . .

Brother saw the scene too. That evening, he said to me,

"...I still don't know if Father remembers me fully. But watching that today, I understood something. He doesn't have to remember everything completely. He's already Father."

"...How do you know that?"

"...You just have to watch what he does," Brother said. "The actions were Father before the words were."

. . .

That night, Father sat the two of us down on either side of him and asked,

"...Will you tell me some old stories? About me. What kind of person I used to be."

Brother hesitated a moment at the question, then slowly began to talk. The days in Brick Hollow, the stories Father used to tell us every evening, the calluses on Father's hands.

Father closed his eyes more than once, listening.

"...He sounds like he was a good person," Father said. Listening to his own story as if it belonged to someone else, there was still something moved in his voice.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, that day, that Father was learning his own story all over again. And the two people who knew that story best were the ones sitting right beside him now.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The Supper We Shared

Previously — Without being able to explain why, Father took off his coat and wrapped it around Elpis. That night he asked for old stories about himself, and listening to the two of them talk, he said, "He sounds like he was a good person."

The day the first snow fell, Mena came again. This time she wasn't alone.

Noa and the children came with her. They said they'd heard the news and walked a long way.

Seeing that many faces gathered in one place felt strange to me. A good strangeness.

Somehow Temel heard the news too, and arrived the next day. He said this was the first time so many people had gathered at Speon's well.

"...Was this place always this quiet?" I asked.

"...Yes," Speon said, smiling. "But not anymore."

. . .

We built a fire by the well and sat around it together. Speon laughed loudly, for the first time in a long while. The children ran through the snow shouting.

Noa spoke quietly to Father.

"...Elpis and Jeteo talked about you so much."

Father looked at us at those words. There was moisture in his eyes.

"...I'm remembering, little by little, too," Father said. "Not all of it, but some."

. . .

As the meal was ending, I happened to look toward the shade of the tree.

He was standing there. Quietly, though no one had called him.

I waved. He gave a small nod. And this time he only watched from a distance. He didn't come closer.

I understood then. He was someone who was always present, and yet never took the place that belonged to us. This evening had to be our evening. He'd known that before we did.

Brother saw him too. This time Brother didn't run to him, and didn't press him with questions. He just raised a hand a little. He nodded back at the gesture.

I remember that brief greeting for a long time after. That there could be a kind of relationship where words weren't necessary — I saw that for the first time that day.

. . .

As the night deepened, people fell asleep one by one. I sat beside Brother and watched the fire.

"...Are you happy?" Brother asked.

I thought about that question for a long time.

"...Not everything's gotten better," I said. "Father still doesn't remember all of it, and Haven's still there, and our names aren't all known yet either."

"...But?"

"...But right now, this moment — it's good," I said.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I learned that a moment could be wholly good, even when nothing was fully resolved.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. Our Ledger (Concluded)

Previously — On the day of the first snow, everyone gathered by the well. The man at the flowerbed only watched from a distance. "Not everything's gotten better, but right now, this moment — it's good." I learned that a moment could be wholly good, even unresolved.

Winter passed, and a sprout came up in the spot where I had planted.

It was small. A little bigger than a fingernail. Small, exactly like the sprout I'd seen in the flowerbed at Haven. I sat in front of it for a long time.

I began this record on the last night in Brick Hollow. That night I wrote that we were wrong. I wrote that this record would be a story about that wrongness. I read that sentence again now.

Speon still keeps the well. Mena still gathers names. The two of them are together often now. I still don't know all of what happened between them. But now I know this: some stories can be stood beside without ever knowing how they end.

Temel set out on the road again. He's out there somewhere, looking for someone else, right now. Noa and the children went back to their tent camp too. Even as they left, they promised to come again. I've decided not to doubt that promise.

. . .

We are still wrong. I still don't have a full answer for why God allows suffering. Neither does Brother. The man at the flowerbed never gave us an answer. He

only ever held out his hand.

Father still doesn't remember all of our names. Some days he looks at Brother's face like a stranger's. Every time it happens, Brother doesn't get angry. He just tells him the name again. However many times it takes, without wearing thin.

I set down that repetition in this record exactly as it is. This isn't a story of complete recovery. This is a story that keeps going.

I think of Brick Hollow sometimes. Of the mother who had to leave us behind, of the old man who fell, of every name we left there. I don't know if I'll ever see them again. But I know this now: I have written every one of their names down in this record. So I won't forget.

. . .

The Ledger is, even now, probably still "resolving" people's grief in Haven. The COMPLETE stamp is probably still coming down somewhere, even now. I didn't bring that city down. We never had the power to.

But I'm holding this stack of paper. Years' worth of record. Names, dates, stories still unfinished. I know this record is different from Haven's ledger. The ledger takes in a request and resolves it. I only listen, and write it down. I resolve nothing. But I forget no one.

I write this now, carefully, as the answer to this whole book. This is not a ledger that stops the weeping. This is a ledger that remembers it.

. . .

Brother still meets the man at the flowerbed now and then. He still doesn't know who he is. He still doesn't declare, "I believe." But now, when Brother sees him,

he doesn't run. I think that's enough.

Father gathered a few stones again today. He still doesn't know who he'll give them to. But I know now. Those stones will end up in our hands, someday. Because the love Father carries in his body has always been turned toward us, before his memory ever was.

I stop this record here, for now. It isn't the end. I will keep writing. We will keep walking. The answers still haven't all come. But I know this now: even when the answers don't all come, having someone to walk with is enough to keep going.

I still don't know that man's name. Someday I will. Until then, I keep writing this ledger. Our ledger.

(The End.)

The Weeping Ledger

Johan Choi